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New York

President: Mr. Yang(Cameroon)

*In the absence of the President, Mr. Da Cruz (Angola), Vice-President,
took the Chair.*

The meeting was called to order at 3.15 p.m.

Agenda item 8 (continued)

General debate

The Acting President: I now give the floor to His Highness Prince Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud, Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia.

Prince Al Saud (Saudi Arabia) (*spoke in Arabic*): I would like to begin by congratulating Mr. Philemon Yang on his election as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session and by thanking Mr. Dennis Francis for his efforts during his presidency at the previous session.

I also take this opportunity to offer our deepest thanks and appreciation to Secretary-General António Guterres for his tireless efforts to achieve the principles and objectives of the Charter of the United Nations.

Since its participation in the founding of the Organization, the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia has been keen to make every possible effort to translate the Charter of the United Nations into a tangible reality by consolidating respect for international law, maintaining international peace and security and supporting channels of multilateral international action in all fields. In that context, the Kingdom participated effectively in drafting the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1), which was adopted by world leaders this week. The Kingdom believes that the Pact and the Summit for the Future in general offer an opportunity to reaffirm common principles, enhance cooperation to confront challenges, achieve security and peace and support sustainable development for future generations. The Kingdom seeks to activate the role of international financial institutions to ensure continued economic recovery and reduce risks.

Our world today is witnessing many crises that have been exacerbated by our efforts to merely manage them without seeking practical solutions to address them,

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due to the laxity of effective international efforts and selectivity in applying international law and international humanitarian law. That has led to a growth in violence and conflicts, threatening the principles of international legitimacy. We must therefore adhere to the principles and foundations established by the United Nations Charter and work together and seriously to focus on long-term peaceful solutions that ensure the protection of civilians, end conflict and wars and provide security and development regionally and internationally.

In the light of the ongoing tensions among countries, the Kingdom warns against political polarization in the international community and seeks to enhance dialogue, understanding and rapprochement among countries, which will enhance global security and peace. In that regard, the Kingdom reiterates its rejection and condemnation of all the heinous crimes committed by Israel against the brotherly Palestinian people. The recent crimes committed against defenceless civilians in the Gaza Strip are only one chapter in the decades-long suffering of that brotherly people. Since last year, the brutal Israeli practices have claimed the lives of tens of thousands of Palestinian civilians, most of them women and children, as a result of systematic bombing, killing, destruction and starvation, amid a major humanitarian disaster that is deteriorating day after day.

Based on our categorical rejection of that bitter reality and the need to take action to end it, the Kingdom hosted the Joint Arab Islamic Extraordinary Summit in Riyadh on 11 November 2023, attended by the Heads of State and Government of the States members of the League of Arab States and the Organization of Islamic Cooperation. The Summit issued decisions that represent the will of all Arab and Islamic peoples and called for an end to the bloodshed, the unhindered delivery of humanitarian assistance and the realization of the legitimate demands of the brotherly Palestinian people for the recovery of their occupied lands and the establishment of their independent State. The Kingdom chaired the Ministerial Committee that was tasked by the Summit with conducting visits to a number of countries in order to urge the international community to shoulder its responsibilities, stop the Israeli aggression and protect civilians.

The Kingdom welcomes the adoption by the General Assembly on 10 May of resolution ES-10/23, stating that the State of Palestine is eligible for full membership of the United Nations. It also welcomes the positive decision taken by the Kingdom of Norway, the Kingdom of Spain, the Republic of Ireland, the Republic of Slovenia and the Republic of Armenia to recognize the sisterly State of Palestine and calls on other countries to consider bilateral recognition. In recognition of our shared responsibility to take serious action towards realizing the recognition of an independent Palestinian State, the Kingdom has announced, with its partners, the members of the Joint Arab Islamic Ministerial Committee, the Kingdom of Norway and the European Union, the launch of an international coalition to implement the two-State solution. We call on all States to join us in that initiative.

The Kingdom has provided more than \$5 billion in aid to the brotherly Palestinian people. Since the beginning of the current crisis in the Gaza Strip, the Kingdom has provided relief and humanitarian aid through the King Salman Center for Relief and Humanitarian Aid, amounting to nearly \$185 million. Agreements have been signed with several United Nations organizations and international humanitarian organizations to implement humanitarian projects, amounting to more than \$106 million. The Kingdom will continue to support the United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees in the Near East (UNRWA) to enable it to provide its relief services, food and medicine and to meet the humanitarian needs of our Palestinian refugee brothers. The Kingdom's total support to UNRWA amounts to more than \$1 billion.

The Kingdom welcomes the advisory opinion issued by the International Court of Justice regarding the policies and practices of Israel in the occupied Palestinian territories and its confirmation of the illegality of the Israeli presence on the occupied Palestinian territories for the past 75 years. The Kingdom stresses the need to take practical and credible steps to reach a just and comprehensive solution to the Palestinian issue, based on the decisions of international legitimacy and the Arab Peace Initiative and in a way that guarantees the right of the brotherly Palestinian people to establish their independent State on the borders of 1967, with its capital in East Jerusalem.

The lack of accountability and punishment, despite Israel's ongoing violations of international law and international humanitarian law, encourages it to escalate, as we have seen in its increasing attacks and violations against Lebanon. That escalation will not achieve security and stability for any party. It portends serious consequences and the expansion of violence and wars and further threatens the security and stability of the region. The Kingdom therefore stresses the need to preserve Lebanon's stability and respect its sovereignty, in accordance with international law and relevant Security Council resolutions. We join in international efforts aimed at establishing an immediate ceasefire to allow for a sustainable diplomatic settlement. We also call on all parties to exercise wisdom and the utmost degree of self-control to spare the region and its peoples from the dangers of wars and their tragedies.

The Kingdom has taken clear steps to ensure calm and development at the regional level. It has reached an agreement with the Islamic Republic of Iran to resume diplomatic relations between our two countries on the basis of respect for the sovereignty of States, non-interference in their internal affairs and adherence to the charters of the United Nations and the Organization of Islamic Cooperation, which will help to consolidate security and stability and advance the progress of regional development and prosperity. We look forward to Iran's cooperation with the international community regarding its nuclear and ballistic missile programmes.

The Kingdom has also resumed its diplomatic relations with the Syrian Arab Republic in order to enhance cooperation and coordination between our two brotherly countries on common issues. The Kingdom is convinced that resolving the Syrian crisis will contribute to the development and stability of the region, while emphasizing the importance of preserving Syria's unity, security, stability and territorial integrity in a way that achieves the good of its brotherly people.

The Kingdom looks forward to the restoration of peace in brotherly Yemen and supports all efforts aimed at resolving the crisis and alleviating the humanitarian suffering of the brotherly Yemeni people and achieving a political solution to restore security and stability to Yemen and the region. We reaffirm our initiative to end the war in Yemen and reach a comprehensive political solution. In the light of the tensions in the Red Sea region, affecting the security and safety of international navigation corridors and global trade, the Kingdom renews its call on the parties to exercise wisdom, avoid escalation and enhance joint efforts to maintain the security and stability of the Red Sea region, where freedom of maritime navigation is an international demand that affects the interests of the entire world.

Regarding the Sudan, the Kingdom affirms its firm position in favour of preserving that country's security, safety and stability, strengthening the cohesion of the State and its institutions and preventing its collapse, and supporting it in confronting the developments and repercussions of the current crisis. The Kingdom hosted the Sudanese peace talks in Jeddah governorate to emphasize the need for calm, an end to military operations and the delivery of humanitarian and relief aid. Work is under way to launch the third round of Jeddah talks to that end.

The Kingdom wishes to see the security, stability and territorial integrity of Afghanistan restored. Afghanistan cannot live in isolation from the regional and international communities, especially in the light of the danger posed by the continued presence of terrorist groups there. We therefore emphasize the importance of limiting the deterioration of the humanitarian, security and economic conditions that give extremist groups and militias the opportunity to strengthen their presence in Afghanistan. We emphasize that economic and development stability can be achieved only in an environment of political and social stability.

With regard to the Russian-Ukrainian crisis, the Kingdom renews its call for an end to the crisis and its negative effects and repercussions on the security and stability of the world. His Royal Highness the Crown Prince and Prime Minister has made goodwill efforts to secure the release of a number of prisoners of various nationalities. Last year, the Kingdom hosted a meeting of national security advisors and representatives of more than 40 countries and international organizations. The Kingdom stresses the need to make every possible effort to end the crisis, resolve differences peacefully, ensure respect for the principles of international law and strive to preserve the security and interests of all. The Kingdom is ready to pursue its mediation efforts between the two parties to the crisis.

The Kingdom, through its Vision 2030, seeks to meet the aspirations of future generations, empower women and young people, develop creativity and innovation, consolidate the values of tolerance and build bridges of communication with the world. Through its development approach, it aims to achieve a comprehensive and sustainable renaissance, focusing on the human person in a way that preserves its rights, enhances its dignity and meets its aspirations.

In the field of energy, the Kingdom is committed to achieving a balance between the three pillars of energy security, providing affordable energy for all and reducing the effects of climate change. The Kingdom is committed to maintaining the stability, reliability and sustainability of global oil markets and to meeting needs in a way that enhances the availability of energy, ease of access to it and the security and safety of supplies so as to ensure a prosperous global economy that benefits producers and consumers. The Kingdom is committed to contributing to reducing the effects of climate change by adopting a comprehensive approach to energy transitions based on a logical, organized and fair basis, so that the goals of the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change and the Paris Agreement on Climate Change can be achieved by taking advantage of all technologies that contribute to addressing greenhouse gas emissions from all sources, including oil and gas, which will remain a pivotal part of the international energy mix for decades to come.

In addition to the Kingdom's possession of technologies that have enabled it to be among those countries with the lowest carbon and methane emissions intensity index in oil and gas operations, it continues to develop other low-emission energy products. In that regard, the Kingdom is working to build a carbon capture, transport and storage complex in Jubail Industrial City, with a capture and storage capacity of up to 9 million tons of carbon dioxide annually by 2027 and a maximum capacity of 44 million tons annually by 2035.

The Kingdom supports the Sustainable Development Goals and international cooperation to confront the challenges of climate change. At the Saudi-African Summit in Riyadh, the Kingdom announced the allocation of approximately \$50 billion to support those efforts and launched several pioneering initiatives based on the circular carbon economy approach, such as the Saudi Green Initiative and the Middle East Green Initiative, in addition to investing in the best technologies, reducing carbon intensity, increasing renewable energy sources in the optimal energy

mix for electricity production, and producing clean hydrogen. We are determined to be a major producer and exporter of all these to the world.

The Kingdom also supports multiple projects that focus on rationalizing consumption, raising energy efficiency, preserving wildlife and sustaining water wealth and marine life. In that regard, in 2024 the Kingdom hosted World Environment Day, affiliated with the United Nations Environment Programme, and will host the sixteenth session of the Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Convention to Combat Desertification at the end of this year to confirm its commitment to protecting the environment and resisting and combating drought and desertification. The Kingdom will also host the eleventh World Water Forum 2027, and in that regard I note the announcement of His Royal Highness the Crown Prince and Prime Minister concerning the establishment of a world water organization in September last year to develop and integrate the efforts of countries and organizations to address water challenges in a comprehensive manner.

The Kingdom is working towards a world free of nuclear weapons and a stable Middle East. It stresses the need for all countries to commit to maintaining the non-proliferation system, while preserving the right of countries to the peaceful use of nuclear energy.

The Kingdom supports the efforts made to confront terrorist organizations and highlights the importance of strengthening joint action and continuing coordination among international partners to confront the threat posed by those groups to our countries and peoples. We emphasize the need to exert greater efforts to limit the impact of the propaganda campaigns launched by terrorist groups. We stress the importance of continuing our work to combat the financing of terrorism and of the need to exchange information related to this matter.

The international community has tasked the Kingdom with hosting the international Expo 2030. The Expo's slogan — "The Era of Change: Together for a Foresighted Tomorrow" — embodies its aspiration to anticipate the future of the planet and useful technological developments, with a focus on the Sustainable Development Goals. The Expo will offer the opportunity to enhance work on projects with a global impact and cooperation in seeking global solutions through innovation, sustainability and inclusiveness in its commitment to developing countries. The Kingdom expresses its thanks and appreciation to the countries that supported its hosting of this global event.

In conclusion, we look forward to our efforts contributing to conveying our message, values and principles to the world in an atmosphere of respect and partnership to build a better future for all humankind.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to His Excellency Mr. Mulambo Hamakuni Haimbe, Minister for Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation of the Republic of Zambia.

Mr. Haimbe (Zambia): I congratulate Mr. Yang on his assumption of the presidency of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session and assure him of Zambia's cooperation during his tenure.

We extend Zambia's sincere gratitude to His Excellency Mr. Dennis Francis for his exemplary work during the seventy-eighth session.

The theme for this session, "Leaving no one behind: acting together for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations", presents an opportunity for us to re-examine our priorities, redefine our mission and sharpen our vision as we approach the eightieth anniversary of the United Nations. Zambia therefore joins the Secretary-General in congratulating

Member States on successfully adopting the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1), which includes the Global Digital Compact and the Declaration on Future Generations. We further appreciate the work of Namibia and Germany in co-facilitating that process. It is our hope that the implementation of the Pact for the Future will address the multiple crises facing the world today.

Zambia firmly believes that multilateralism is the only viable approach to solving regional and international challenges. In that regard, the creation of the United Nations almost 80 years ago provided new hope for the international community in the maintenance of international peace and security, the promotion of justice and the improvement of living conditions for all people. However, that ideal is rapidly slipping away as global peace is increasingly threatened by the growing and sustained geopolitical tensions.

As Member States that share in the ideals upon which the United Nations was founded, we must resolve to correct that course and uphold the principles enshrined in the Charter of the United Nations. The impact of conflict in some parts of the world has been felt across Africa through disruptions and the soaring prices of key commodities such as energy and other inputs of trade and production, resulting in an increased cost of living. Zambia, like many other developing countries which are predominantly import-dependent, has not been spared. It is therefore crucial that we address the root causes and structural drivers of conflict and promote peacebuilding efforts. We call on all warring parties to exercise restraint and flexibility for the sake of millions of civilians who are casualties of war and conflict. That call is particularly relevant to the raging conflicts in the Sudan, the Middle East and Ukraine.

At the regional level, Zambia held the chairmanship of Southern African Development Community (SADC) Organ on Politics, Defence and Security Cooperation for the period August 2023 to August 2024, and therefore played a crucial role in the region in that capacity. Overall, the security and political situation in the region remains stable. However, there are still pockets of security challenges in some of our member States, such as the situation in the eastern parts of the Democratic Republic of the Congo and the Cabo Delgado province of Mozambique, which SADC remains seized with.

We implore the international community to support the various peacebuilding efforts in the Democratic Republic of the Congo. We further call for support to the Government of Mozambique in order to ensure that the exit of the SADC Mission in Mozambique does not result in reversal of the gains made by the Mission. Furthermore, Zambia recognizes the efforts of Mr. João Manuel Gonçalves Lourenço, President of the Republic of Angola, as the African Union mediator in the facilitation of the Luanda process aimed at restoring peace and Security in the eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo, as well as the Nairobi process, which is also aimed at fostering peace in that country.

Climate change and extreme weather conditions threaten the very existence and balance of the world as we know it. It is clear that efforts to raise the standard of living for the world's poor are being adversely affected by the effects of climate change. For instance, this year Zambia experienced its worst drought in recent times. That led the Government to declare the drought a national disaster and emergency to save lives and safeguard livelihoods. We take this opportunity to thank all our bilateral and multilateral partners who graciously responded to the clarion call to support Zambia's drought response strategy. That and similar scenarios in our region underscore the need to build local resilience and climate adaptation through various interventions including, among others, climate financing from both public and private sources. In that regard, the need for the full actualization of the Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage to help developing countries cope with climate-related disasters

and extreme weather events cannot be overemphasized. We urge Member States to focus their energies on achieving measurable outcomes at the forthcoming twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change accordingly.

It is becoming increasingly apparent that the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) may not be met by 2030, as only 17 per cent of the SDG targets are on track, while the remaining 83 per cent are either stagnating or regressing. Therefore, Zambia joins calls for massive investment and scaled-up action in order to close the financing gap, which is currently estimated to be around \$4 trillion. Failure to close the gap will adversely impact future generations. In the same vein, we call on the international community to scale up financing for developing countries to achieve the SDGs, including by honouring commitments to contribute at least 0.7 per cent of gross national income towards official development assistance. Further, the heavy burden of debt in some developing countries presents another major hurdle to the attainment of the SDGs, especially in Africa. Those countries face a high risk of debt distress. There is need, therefore, for an effective debt work-out mechanism that supports payment suspensions, longer lending terms and lower interest rates.

Based on Zambia's experience, we call for further reforms to streamline the existing Group of 20 Framework for Debt Treatments in order to enhance certainty and reduce the time it takes to conclude the process. Zambia further joins calls for the reform of the international financial architecture to make it fit for purpose and equitably address the development needs of all countries in the twenty-first century. Additionally, there is need to build capacities for least developed countries to access other innovative financing measures such as debt-for-climate swaps and green and blue bonds, among others. Furthermore, Zambia joins other SADC member States in the call for a review of the use of unilateral economic instruments that curtail the access of developing countries to development financing.

Aggressive tax avoidance and tax evasion have a corrosive effect on public trust, financial integrity, the rule of law and sustainable development across the globe. International tax cooperation could significantly reduce illicit financial flows, a scourge that deprives economies, especially those in the developing world, of funding for development. Zambia therefore calls for the urgent conclusion of negotiations on the proposed United Nations framework convention on international tax cooperation. That will enable developing countries to enhance their domestic resource mobilization. As co-facilitator of the negotiations of the outcome document for the fourth International Conference on Financing for Development in the coming months, we look forward to actively engaging with Member States in the reform of the international architecture.

Science and technology are critical to achieving the SDGs. Developing countries' lack of access to technology has hindered the implementation of sustainable development practices, thereby perpetuating the cycle of poverty and inequality. Hence, there is a need to bridge the gap in digital technologies, including artificial intelligence, to promote efficiencies in health, climate, sustainable infrastructure, energy, agriculture and other global development priorities. In that regard, we call for enhanced international cooperation to support developing countries in integrating technology through capacity-building, technology transfer on mutually agreed terms, information exchange and investments in research and development.

Alongside the Pact for the Future, Member states adopted the Global Digital Compact. Zambia was honoured to partner with Sweden in leading negotiations on that historic document.

As part of its efforts to accelerate the attainment of the SDGs by 2030, Zambia has been implementing policies and programmes aimed at creating a strong and resilient health system, reducing inequalities, eradicating poverty and empowering women and girls. That is also consistent with the implementation of the International Conference on Population and Development Programme of Action. Zambia welcomes the Declaration on Future Generations, which seeks to secure the well-being of future generations, in particular their participation in decision-making. To reap the demographic dividend, Zambia continues to call for significant investments in the growing youth population, currently standing at 82 per cent below the age of 35. Increased investments are needed in the education, health care and empowerment of young people so that they can meaningfully contribute to the achievement of the SDGs.

Child, early and forced marriage is a harmful practice that disproportionately affects girls, hindering their education, health and overall well-being. In that regard, Zambia continues to make strides in the campaign to end child marriage by 2030 and safeguard the rights of girls by enacting relevant legislation to address that vice. President Hakainde Hichilema being the African Union Champion on Ending Child Marriage, Zambia is pleased to report that the campaign is growing from strength to strength, with 32 of the 54 countries on the continent having launched national campaigns to end child marriage. However, much more needs to be done. We call on all partners to join efforts and raise our voices to protect our children to end that harmful practice by 2030.

In the face of the present geopolitical realities and calls to strengthen multilateralism, the need to reform the Security Council cannot be over emphasized. Reforms are necessary to make the Security Council better equipped and strengthened in its capacity to discharge its responsibilities of maintaining and safeguarding international peace and security. The representation of African States in the permanent category would correct the historical injustice that has marginalized Africa's voice and provide a vital perspective to the Council.

The time has come for the Security Council to be representative, democratic and accountable to all Member States, irrespective of status. That is essential to its integrity as the custodian of international peace. Given that Africa constitutes the second largest bloc of the United Nations membership, proposals to reform the Security Council should heed Africa's call as espoused in the Common Africa Position, as enshrined in the Ezulwini Consensus and the Sirte Declaration. In that regard, we are pleased to note that the African Union Committee of Ten and the five permanent members of the Security Council held a meeting during this session of the General Assembly. Such interactions should be encouraged in order to narrow the gap on the Security Council reforms,

Finally, I wish to reaffirm that Zambia remains committed to strengthened multilateralism as a means of addressing the numerous global challenges affecting our people, including ending poverty and creating wealth in a sustainable manner. To that end, we should not remain indecisive or indifferent to that serious issue, nor should we forego this opportunity to make the world a better place for all humankind.

In conclusion, I would like to reiterate the need for us to seriously consider the call for massive investment and scaled-up action if we are to make meaningful progress in achieving the SDGs, including the implementation of the Pact for the Future.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to His Excellency Mr. Maxim Ryzhenkov, Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Belarus.

Mr. Ryzhenkov (Belarus) (*spoke in Russian*): For 79 years now, our countries have been meeting in this Hall to speak their own truth, exchange best practices and support important initiatives, all under the motto of making the world a better place.

But is the world really becoming better, more predictable, safer or more stable? There are old-timers among us who may remember the time when the United Nations played a special role in that regard. Unfortunately, we less seasoned participants know it only from textbooks. Many years ago, the Charter of the United Nations was unshakable, a true guarantor of compromise and forward-looking solutions. Many still recalled the victims and horrors of the Second World War and no one wanted a repeat of that terrible tragedy. Therefore, together we formed a unique instrument for collective dispute resolution and strengthening the architecture of international cooperation.

Yes, as history has shown, the instrument is not perfect in everything, just as we are not, but it is undoubtedly the best the world has had and has. Not all issues, even those with clear outcomes, have been successfully addressed and blood continues to flow as a result. A good example of that is Palestine, where a true humanitarian catastrophe is unfolding, and tens of thousands of civilians are dying.

But that does not diminish the achievements of the past century. The colonial system was destroyed. Many nations received the hard-won right to independent development. Hubs of economic, industrial and financial growth appeared on all continents. Entire regions began to emerge from the shadow of hunger and epidemics. United Nations peacekeeping activities were able to prevent or help end bloody conflicts. The United Nations blue was seen everywhere where problems were successfully solved for the purposes of development.

But what is happening today? Why did we need to create the Group of Friends in Defence of the Charter of the United Nations? Why are we forced today to defend a document that already has the highest legal force for everyone? Why can we not fully use the United Nations tools to restore order in the world?

The answer is obvious. It is because a number of countries do not live by the norms prescribed by the Charter and do not intend to because for them abiding by international law is akin to slow extinction. Of course, they refer to the Charter when they speak from this rostrum, but not in any universal sense; rather, they do so only insofar as it serves their own selfish interests and claims, often in relation to others. I recall that the law of the United Nations is universal and gives everyone without exception equal rights to development and equal non-discriminatory access to common goods, technologies and resources.

Is that approach acceptable to the West? It is clearly not. Its main interest is maintaining dominance on the planet and ensuring the well-being of its elites. To that end, entire nations and foreign resources are exploited and the development of the rest of the world is constrained. The age-old principle of divide-and-conquer is applied everywhere and in fact forms the basis of all modern military conflicts. All United Nations principles are relegated to the back shelf when it comes to the so-called vital interests of the United States and its satellites, but if a State dares to pursue a policy in the interests of its own people or tries to throw off the yoke of external control over its resources, the West suddenly recalls all the conventions, their provisions and even their most insignificant footnotes. Most importantly, the entire gamut of illegal sanctions and pressure is applied to anyone who disagrees. That is the nature of all so-called colour revolutions, which lead only to suffering and upheaval for ordinary people. It is the path of the West and its recipe for a new world — a recipe, by the way, that is generously seasoned with NATO weapons.

Let us take a look at that. Today, some 40 countries with a total population of 2.5 billion are under illegal, unilateral restrictive measures imposed by the United States and the European Union (EU). Many have been living in such conditions for decades, while freedom-loving Cuba has done so for more than half a century. That instrument grossly violates entire sections of international law and the United Nations Charter. It unlawfully hinders sustainable development, undermines food and energy security, restricts access to global markets and violates the right to freedom of movement. It also has a boomerang effect on ordinary people in the initiating countries. In our EU neighbours, we are seeing people complain about ever-increasing energy and food prices, as well as social upheaval.

What is the outcome of all this? From the point of view of the collective West — my information is taken from American sources — 72 per cent of the world's population lives in so-called autocracies. Twenty years ago, that figure, according to their own estimates, was 46 per cent. So has the West's policy of forcing the international community to live according to its own template been successful? The answer is obviously and clearly not.

In general, the trend is also obvious — the free countries of the global South do not accept the sanctions, interference in their internal affairs or so-called democratization foisted on them. They want to develop on the basis of their own historical traditions, their understanding of the world and in the interests of their peoples. Today they are the global majority, within which new, exclusively peaceful ideas and projects are emerging in the interests of the entire world community, and not against anyone. That includes the Chinese Belt and Road initiative and the Global Development Initiative, the Global Security Initiative and the Global Civilization Initiative put forward by the President of the People's Republic of China, Mr. Xi Jinping. It also includes the Belarusian-Russian idea of the Eurasian Charter of Diversity and Multipolarity in the Twenty-First Century, the Indian Voice of the Global South initiative and many others.

To one degree or another, all of those projects are aimed at establishing an international community with a single destiny for the entire planet, and not just for the so-called golden billion. After all, we have one planet in all its diversity, which enriches us all. That is our path — the path of our President Alexandr Lukashenko and our people. It is based on respect, trust, sincerity, reliability and responsibility. Indeed, Belarus has responded to the latest package of illegal sanctions with openness and has unilaterally waived the visa regime for citizens of all EU countries. Thousands of EU citizens have already taken advantage of the waiver by visiting our country and have not been disappointed. They saw no dictators anywhere.

If we placed greater trust in the United Nations, most global peace initiatives would be born and developed within the Organization itself, not outside it, and the world would not be threatened with a new fragmentation into political and economic blocs.

Let me say a few, somewhat unusual words about the potential for conflict on the planet. We are all accustomed to third-rate works of fiction and brief, completely useless YouTube videos. We have grown accustomed to that simplistic way of receiving information, forcing us to forget the truths that many famous humanists and writers have written in the past. In that regard, I deliberately turn to three Western writers — one English and two American — to draw some parallels with modern events.

I shall quote first from the work *Cabbage and Kings*, written 100 years ago by the beloved O. Henry:

“The little *opéra-bouffe* nations play at government and intrigue until some day a big, silent gunboat glides into the offing and warns them not to break their toys.”

That would be an American ship.

Next, I recall Graham Greene and his *The Quiet American*, written 70 years ago, in which an undercover CIA operative in the United States Embassy in Viet Nam seeks a third force in order to organize a coup in that country through a series of terrorist attacks and install forces loyal to America to power.

Last, I will mention Kurt Vonnegut’s *A Man Without a Country*, written roughly 50 years ago. Vonnegut could not understand why the United States of America and Great Britain needed to carpet bomb the city of Dresden at the very end of the Second World War, when the outcome of the war was already clear, burying more than 100,000 old people, children and women under the rubble. We know why they did it — to make them fear the future. That is very similar to what we are seeing today in many places in the world — meddling, provocations and real American warships, and not just one but many.

That is precisely why we need a strong and impartial universal international Organization capable of guaranteeing balance in the world, in which no country or bloc of countries will be able to exploit the United Nations instruments to satisfy its own selfish desires, to the detriment of the global majority. A strong Organization would not allow Ukraine to fight to the last Ukrainian to benefit transnational capital and in the interests of the collective West. If everyone understood, as neighbouring Belarus does, what is really happening in the conflict zone and what the real threat is, and genuinely wanted to stop the bloody confrontation between two fraternal peoples, then Ukraine would have long ago found itself alongside Russia, not on the battlefield but at the peace negotiating table. In that context, initiatives like the Brazil-China peace plan are very timely. However, no project will be successful without Russia’s participation. There can be no new security architecture in our region without the participation of Belarus.

In the meantime, NATO continues to multiply its military capabilities on our western borders, deploying tens of thousands of soldiers and thousands of pieces of equipment. We are seriously concerned that the game may spin out of control and lead to an escalation of the conflict on a regional or even global scale, with catastrophic consequences for everyone. There are enough nuclear weapons in Europe. Therefore, the escalation of tension is a direct path to a third world war.

Ten years ago, Minsk became the venue for effective negotiations to resolve the conflict in Ukraine. We are still offering our peacekeeping efforts because we know and understand Russians and Ukrainians better than anyone else. We will do everything in our power to achieve peace in long-suffering Ukraine. We have a greater interest in it than anyone.

By way of general information, more than 250,000 Ukrainians have crossed our EU border into Belarus since the beginning of the conflict. That figure has recently risen to 12,000 to 15,000 a month. Those are the official figures. People do not flee today’s prosperous Europe to the aggressor. By the way, that number is several times higher than the number of refugees crossing our border into the EU. The shameless expulsion of migrants into Belarus is another dirty page in the book of European democracy. On our border with the EU, the military of some EU countries have beaten and tortured thousands of refugees from Asia, Africa and the Middle East with impunity. Dozens have been killed, as confirmed by independent international sources, and many buried without identification.

Mr. Chaivaivid (Thailand), Vice-President, took the Chair.

The Council of Europe recently unequivocally condemned such actions and criticized a new Polish law that expands the scope of the legal use of firearms by Polish military personnel against refugees. That is how so-called enlightened Europe greets those who flee the horrors and upheavals that have resulted from the policies and interference of the collective West in the sovereign affairs of foreign countries. Such actions are a flagrant violation of the 1951 United Nations Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees. All facts have been recorded in detail and will soon be sent to the relevant international bodies, although those bodies should have dealt with that issue themselves long ago. We are therefore concerned about how we will forge the path to strengthening the foundations of the United Nations.

First, the United Nations must free itself from the dictates of individual States that do as they see fit and see themselves as exceptional. The United Nations is all of us. Secretariat staff must remember that, when they become United Nations employees, they work in the interests of the entire Organization and not to please the countries of their citizenship. They are therefore obliged to be objective, impartial and independent.

Secondly, the Organization must work to support regional processes, since regionalism is a key reality of today. We are seeing the continual strengthening of regional integration processes in various parts of the planet. The associations of the countries of the global majority are gaining momentum in their activities. Those include the Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa group, the Shanghai Cooperation Organization, the Commonwealth of Independent States, the Eurasian Economic Union, the African Union, the Association of Southeast Asian Nations and many others. I talked about the reason for that earlier. The United Nations needs to integrate itself into those processes, promoting their development and conjugation.

Thirdly, last year Western countries staged a dirty campaign to prevent the election of Belarus to the Security Council. They were very afraid of our honest voice in that organ. However, outside the Council we will speak out directly and openly on the entire spectrum of global problems. Moreover, we will continue to insist on a fair reform of the Security Council because the voice of the global majority countries on the Council is also our voice. We therefore believe that the urgent need of the day is to reform the Security Council by including major developing countries of Asia, Africa and Latin America. Those countries are at the forefront of major global problems. They know better than anyone else how to resolve wars and conflicts in the developing world, and their weight in world affairs today is much greater than it was 80 years ago.

Fourthly, the United Nations must have a fundamental say on the unacceptability of unilateral measures. We have the right to expect serious and objective assessments from the Organization on the negative impact of sanctions on sustainable development processes that we all support. Moreover, we believe it necessary to establish the work of the United Nations to counteract illegal sanctions on a systemic footing. All such cases should be given a fundamental objective assessment.

Fifthly, we must use the United Nations as a platform for effectively addressing ever-growing transnational threats. Belarus has always been committed to a collective approach to solving such common global problems as migration, pandemics, natural disasters, human trafficking, hunger and many others.

Outside the walls of this Hall there is a counter that is recording in real time the money spent on weapons. It amounts to trillions of dollars, and that is only the money the United Nations knows about. Let the countries of the so-called golden billion use those trillions not to unleash and fuel more wars and conflicts, but to resolve issues

vital to humanity. Many global problems would thereby be solved immediately. The United Nations would receive the resources that are necessary for development and are persistently insufficient, while donors claim they have no money, and the world would finally see the desire of the self-styled hegemony to be responsible for solving and not creating global problems. Furthermore, the United Nations should be the voice of the States, undiluted by that of various non-State structures. After all, it is the Member States that take decisions in the Organization that affect the fate of all people on the planet and are fully responsible for their implementation.

This year is very significant for the Republic of Belarus. We recently celebrated the eightieth anniversary of our liberation from the fascist invaders. That date marked the start of a new chapter in our country's history — one that is peaceful and creative. We are proud to have created a socially oriented State where caring for people is the most important priority of national policy.

Next year, we will all celebrate the eightieth anniversary of the creation of the United Nations. How will the world approach that important milestone? Will it be entangled in quarrels and conflicts? That is why the President of Belarus Alexander Lukashenko has put forward the initiative to hold a global dialogue on security that closely dovetails with other proposals made today and yesterday by many representatives from this rostrum. We will continue to knock on the doors of peace, constructive action, security and development.

Last year, we began holding an international conference on Eurasian security in Minsk with a view to consolidating political, economic and other processes in greater Eurasia, to the benefit of our States and peoples. This year, it will be held on 31 October. We invite everyone to attend. We must once again fill the lungs of the United Nations with the spirit of San Francisco that gave life to our Organization. We are convinced that this is vitally necessary today. It is necessary in the interests of all people on the planet.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to Her Excellency Ms. Thórdís Kolbrún Reykjaförð Gylfadóttir, Minister for Foreign Affairs of Iceland.

Ms. Gylfadóttir (Iceland): First, I would like to once again thank all those whose daily work is dedicated to the United Nations and its ideals.

All across the globe, people work in the name of the United Nations, wearing the colours and emblems of the United Nations, giving their efforts to make our world a better place and often doing work that only the United Nations is capable of doing. In these Headquarters and other United Nations offices, hundreds of people show up every day to ensure that the nations of the world can count on the Organization to be the forum where the biggest challenges facing humankind can be discussed, debated, and — I hope — set on a path of resolution.

Next year will mark the eightieth anniversary of the United Nations. The United Nations emerged out of calamity, holding the promise of a brighter future — a promise of the peaceful settlement of disputes, universal human rights and the opportunity for all to enjoy peace and prosperity. Despite setbacks, wrong turns and many bad decisions, these past 80 years have indeed been the most peaceful and prosperous that humankind has experienced.

For my own nation, 1944 also marked a new beginning, with Iceland becoming a republic. Iceland's status as an independent nation has been defended not primarily by weapons or alliances but by a robust system of international law, mutually beneficial cooperation and strong and universally respected international institutions. For us, it is paramount to safeguard this multilateral system.

When the United Nations was founded, it was a time of change and a time that demanded decisions. It was also, it seems to me, a time of creativity in the face of destruction, a time of determination despite despair, and a time for hope to triumph over horror. By founding the United Nations, the leaders of the world's nations set a path guided by a shared vision for a peaceful and prosperous world, faith in fundamental human rights and the equality of nations, large and small. But as Secretary-General António Guterres recently stated when speaking about the Summit of the Future, “we cannot build a future fit for our grandchildren with systems built for our grandparents” — or, in the case of a person my age, a system created for my great-grandparents to build a future fit for my own generation and my children.

These are also times of profound change. All around the world, technology is fundamentally changing how people experience reality and, to quote Mr. Guterres again, those technologies are being developed “in a moral and legal vacuum, without governance or guardrails”. That is no small thing, and it is not something that leaders and politicians can treat as trivial or unconnected to other policy issues.

While elected representatives and leaders debate how to address challenges that we face, and while we attempt to guide our societies towards a better future, there is an ongoing battle for people's attention, convictions and beliefs being waged through increasingly addictive technologies, often self-guided by overwhelmingly powerful and completely unprincipled algorithms. That battle will not necessarily be won by those who share a belief in peace and prosperity or have faith in fundamental human rights and the equality of nations large and small.

As those staggering changes are taking place in our information environment, the world is facing the greatest number of armed conflicts since the Second World War and democratic institutions worldwide are facing a loss of trust. Those developments are not happening in a vacuum. In her address accepting the Nobel Peace Prize in Oslo in 2021, Philippine journalist Maria Ressa pointed out that, “without facts, you cannot have truth. Without truth, you cannot have trust”. Ressa continued, “without trust, we have no shared reality, no democracy, and it becomes impossible to deal with our world's existential problems.”

Sadly, to an ever more obvious extent, that prospect of a lack of shared reality has now become fact. Malign actors are actively undermining social order across the globe; they are spreading suspicion and fear and fuelling despair and rage. They may use technology, but their target is always the very essence of what we are as human beings. The individual rights that have proven vital to the functioning of democratic societies are being subverted. That is why I said in my address to this body one year ago that “human rights are for human beings” and that freedom of expression “is not for programmed bots that spread hate, lies and fear” (*A/78/PV.12, p. 49*). That is a challenge that we have not yet solved.

Freedom cannot exist without accountability and, to paraphrase American historian Timothy Snyder, it must always involve some risk. We know that sacrificing individual rights because of those risks is an unacceptable proposition, akin to burning down the house to kill a spider. An individual, even one with questionable and dangerous opinions, has the right to be heard. In a true democracy, we accept the risks associated with the freedom of speech, but we must be careful not to let our freedom be hijacked by those who evade accountability and take no risk. The current danger does not come from free individuals who advocate for their own misguided, crazy or evil ideas, but from vast networks of paid and unpaid agents alike, made-up trolls hiding in the shadows, entirely unaccountable for their poisonous contribution to public discourse. That sort of speech is no more a manifestation of the freedom of expression than a forced gathering to salute a dictator is an example of freedom of assembly.

Those are issues that exemplify the urgent need for a strong multilateral system. However, that system cannot be left to provide answers to how to maintain itself. The real power lies with national Governments and leaders across the world. All of us who are entrusted with positions of authority and influence in our own societies must shoulder our responsibility to maintain and strengthen a multilateral system based on the Charter of the United Nations. For that, we need more interaction, more humanity and much more unscripted interactions at the highest levels.

Russia's full-scale aggression against Ukraine, the Sudan's civil war and the devastating conflicts in the Middle East all rage on while other longer-running conflicts grow protracted. One thing that they all have in common is that innocent civilians bear the highest cost. By invading Ukraine and violently seizing its territory, the Russian Federation has committed a flagrant breach of the United Nations Charter and derogated from its primary obligations as a permanent member of the Security Council to uphold international peace and security. The Russian Federation's repeated threats of using nuclear weapons are reckless and dangerous.

In the case of the Russian Federation's actions, there should be no doubt about who is in the right and who is in the wrong. It is Mr. Putin who has concocted a false narrative around his invasion of Ukraine's territory. It is he who started that senseless war and it is in the Kremlin's power to end it at any time by withdrawing its forces from all the territory that is internationally recognized as belonging to Ukraine. The Russian Federation's disdain for the principles of the United Nations Charter is on full display in Ukraine, but it is also pervasive in many other parts of the world, with ongoing insidious efforts to subvert democratic norms and incite violence and chaos.

Israel's right to exist is beyond debate. Iceland has condemned in the strongest terms the horrific attack on Israel on 7 October 2023. We continue to call for the immediate and unconditional release of all hostages. But no country is above the law, and the Palestinian people's right to self-determination is also beyond debate. In the current conflict, the world has witnessed the limitations of sending humanitarian aid, water and power to Gaza. That is simply unacceptable. There have been reports of civilian infrastructure and hospitals being used for purposes that can deprive them of their protection under international humanitarian law. That is also unacceptable. We have also witnessed unacceptable losses of civilian lives — children, aid and health care workers, journalists and United Nations staff — and journalists are being denied access to the war zone and silenced.

Iceland condemns all violations of international law, including international humanitarian law. International law provides States with rights and obligations. Both are sacred. Again, we call on all parties to agree to an immediate ceasefire and to avoid any action that could lead to further escalation. A clear political path to peace must follow a ceasefire, entailing the establishment of two States living side-by-side in peace and security. With that aim, and as confirmed by the International Court of Justice, Israel must immediately cease all new settlement activities and bring its unlawful presence to an end.

Our worst fears of an escalation have now been realized with the bloodiest days that Lebanon has seen in years. And still, we must brace ourselves for even worse, with the conflict spiralling further out of control. The parties have been warned of the cost and the danger of that development. It must stop, for the sake of humanity.

In 10 days, the General Assembly will convene to elect 18 new members to the Human Rights Council for the term 2025-2027. Iceland is a candidate in those elections, hoping to serve for a second time on that important body. We have submitted our candidature out of a deep conviction that respect for human rights and the rule of law, justice and fairness are key to a prosperous society.

In his opening address to the Assembly on Tuesday, Secretary-General Guterres pointed out that fewer than 10 per cent of all speakers this week would be female (see A/79/PV.7). In our estimate, I am one of only 19 women speaking from this podium in the general debate. I thought we had come further than that, but of course I am truly one of the lucky ones. It is beyond my comprehension that there exist in this world, in these enlightened times, societies of human beings where little girls and women are not allowed to go to school, and that there exists in this world of ours a society where little girls are not allowed to laugh in public and women are not allowed to take part in conversations outside the confines of their homes. A teenage girl in Afghanistan who sings a happy song in public runs the risk of being arrested, of being humiliated, of being ostracized, of being beaten or even worse. How has the world come to this? That is why Iceland supports the cross-regional action announced this week here in New York to hold the Taliban to account for its grave violations of the Convention on the Elimination of all Forms of Discrimination Against Women.

Those whose sexual orientation differs from the common norm are suffering backlash, too. While we have thankfully seen a significant shift towards the decriminalization of consensual same-sex relations, we are also witnessing laws adopted to establish or expand criminal sanctions contrary to the basic universal norms that all States have agreed. I do not understand why people should not be allowed the freedom to love and be loved for who they are. Increased individual freedom and happiness should never worry politicians or Governments that have real problems to solve. I am proud to confirm that if elected to the Human Rights Council, Iceland will include LGBTQI+ rights among list of priorities during our term on the Council.

Iceland strongly emphasizes global actions against climate change, for both mitigation and adaptation. Climate change is not a distant threat; it is a reality already impacting the lives and livelihoods of millions of people. Climate change threatens the health of the ocean, which Iceland is highly dependent on. A healthy ocean and a healthy planet are matters of economic prosperity and well-being.

One of the many meetings I attended this week was a high-level meeting on sea level rise, which strongly indicates that our ocean environment is destabilizing. That is yet another challenge we must address, and we believe that it is only through more determined climate change mitigation that we can limit the effects of sea level rise. Taking on that challenge, as well as ensuring that respect is shown for rules and regulations that we have agreed to abide by concerning our behaviour at sea, is of great importance to a nation like Iceland, which relies heavily on the ocean around us. The United Nations has a proven record in that arena, primarily with the Convention for the Law of the Sea, a particularly important agreement in our view and that of all maritime nations. Therefore, it is of great concern that the law of the sea is being challenged and undermined, including in the South China Sea. We call on all Member States to honour their commitments and act in accordance with the law of the sea.

We must work together for a more stable and prosperous world, and Iceland is set on contributing more to sustainable development. Our recently adopted policy for international development cooperation supports that with the overarching goals of poverty eradication, respect for human rights and improved living standards. It foresees a significant increase in official development assistance. Given our own experience, we will continue our firm focus on gender equality, women's empowerment, sexual and reproductive health and rights, and eradicating gender-based violence. Crucially, we will increase our efforts to strengthen civil rights and improve social and legal protection for LGBTQI+ persons.

It falls on all of us to support the vital work of the United Nations and other partners in addressing the dire status of humanitarian affairs. The number of refugees and internally displaced persons has never been higher, as increasing levels of fragility know no geographical boundaries.

We are meeting at a time when the multilateral system is under the greatest pressure it has faced since the establishment of the United Nations. Meanwhile, it is abundantly clear that without multilateralism, without international cooperation and without respect for international law, the downward spiral of crises and conflict will only accelerate. The adoption of the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1) offers an encouraging sign, a collective recognition that it is only together that we can work for a better world and that we need new tools in these times of change.

The choice is ours — either we take on the responsibility to guard the foundations of multilateralism, the United Nations Charter and international law, or we succumb to a world of might makes right, which surely will only lead us to disaster. The choice is clear. We must work together to protect and promote the fundamental principles and values underpinning the vision of the United Nations founders and on which this great Organization is built. We must ensure that the United Nations system, including the Security Council, keeps up with the times and reforms and adapts to changing realities. Taking that step will require courage and strong political will.

Over and beyond, we must recognize that the world needs the United Nations more than ever before and that we cannot and must not fail to make our Organization the best possible version of itself. The multilateral system deserves to be defended in the same spirit of creativity, under the same promise of hope and with the same steadfast determination that guided the hands of those who brought the Organization into existence almost 80 years ago.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to His Excellency Mr. Sayyid Badr bin Hamad bin Hamood Albusaidi, Foreign Minister of the Sultanate of Oman.

Mr. Albusaidi (Oman) (*spoke in Arabic*): It gives me great pleasure to extend to Mr. Philemon Yang and his friendly country, the Republic of Cameroon, our sincere congratulations on his election as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session.

We are also pleased to express our deep appreciation for the efforts made by his predecessor from friendly Trinidad and Tobago during his presidency of the previous session.

We would like to express our deepest gratitude to Secretary-General António Guterres for his tireless efforts in leading the United Nations and his unwavering resolve to uphold and implement international law in the pursuit of justice and peace, reflecting the vision of the United Nations of a world in which security, stability, peace and prosperity prevail for all. We affirm the Sultanate of Oman's full support for the efforts of the Secretary-General and the United Nations in promoting international peace and security, and express our strong support for the Charter of the United Nations, recognizing the importance of the United Nations in embodying the hopes and aspirations of peoples for development and a dignified and prosperous life.

The foreign policy of the Sultanate of Oman is founded on a steadfast vision that embraces an approach of dialogue and tolerance in addressing all issues and challenges. It is a vision that seeks to achieve peace and build relations based on mutual respect, positive cooperation and harmony among nations.

The leadership, the Government and the people of the Sultanate of Oman believe in the use of legitimate and peaceful means to resolve issues and conflicts.

Accordingly, my country calls for an immediate ceasefire and cessation of hostilities in the Gaza Strip, Lebanon and the Red Sea region. We emphasize the need to address the root causes of those conflicts by ending the illegal Israeli occupation of Palestinian territories and achieving justice for the Palestinian people on the basis of the two-State solution and the establishment of an independent Palestinian State, with East Jerusalem as its capital, within the 1967 borders. Oman stresses the need to grant Palestine full membership of the United Nations, end the genocide policies carried out by the Israeli occupation forces against the Palestinian people, and alleviate their humanitarian suffering.

We believe in the importance of stepping up efforts to contain escalation and tension and end the bloodshed by adhering to reasonable dialogue, the rules of international law, the Charter of the United Nations and the resolutions of international legitimacy, and by respecting the sovereignty and territorial integrity of States and non-interference in their internal affairs, ensuring that all nations and peoples can live in peace, security and dignity.

The Sultanate of Oman is moving forward with its programmes in the field of social protection through a comprehensive system that supports various sectors of society, including women, children, the elderly and people with disabilities, as well as social insurance and job security programmes. That reflects the progress achieved by the Sultanate of Oman in the field of sustainable development and its continuous efforts to develop these programmes in line with the best international practices, while continuing to provide educational, health and social care to all members of society. My country also affirms its ongoing support for and empowerment of young people, whom we consider to be the pillar of the future and the axis of sustainable development. We believe that young people are the driving force for innovation, growth and progress. We are resolved to create opportunities that will enable them to apply their skills and contribute effectively to building a brighter future.

Oman stresses the importance of promoting respect and peaceful coexistence among peoples and calls for combating all forms of discrimination, racism, hatred and violence. Oman is also making great efforts to address the challenges of climate change, reduce emissions and stimulate investment in renewable energy projects. Our net-zero carbon strategy for 2050 is driven by clean energy projects, green hydrogen initiatives and nature-based solutions. That commitment arises from our belief in the importance of protecting the environment and preserving natural resources for future generations, while balancing economic development and environmental sustainability.

Oman's efforts and development programmes are in line with its national vision, embodied in Oman Vision 2040, which is aimed at achieving the goals of economic and social development and facing future challenges. In that context, the Sultanate of Oman has submitted its second voluntary national report, which reflects its deep commitment to the global principles and objectives of sustainable development and highlights the progress made in various spheres of development. In that context, we welcome the adoption of the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1). We commend collective international efforts leading to that achievement, which outline a road map for the world to enhance international cooperation and effectively address global challenges. We therefore urge all Member States to commit to implementing the Pact, its vision and goals through fruitful cooperation and knowledge exchange, and to adopt it as a path towards achieving a better, safer and more prosperous future for future generations.

We sincerely hope that this session will be successful.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to His Excellency Mr. Lars Løkke Rasmussen, Minister for Foreign Affairs of Denmark.

Mr. Løkke Rasmussen (Denmark): The high-level week is a welcome reminder that the vast majority of nations, large and small, seeks global unity and that the division we talk so much about is sought only by the few. That gives me great hope, yet as we open the seventy-ninth session of the General Assembly, we cannot close our eyes to the fact that conflicts and war are raging across the world.

It is utterly unacceptable that a permanent member of the Security Council continues to violate the most basic principles of the Charter of the United Nations. Wars of aggression and altering borders are and should remain things of the past — an imperial practice that has absolutely no place in the twenty-first century. Denmark will continue to stand by Ukraine as long as it takes and to support a just and lasting peace. The Summit on Peace in Ukraine that was held in Switzerland in June clearly showed that there is strong global support for peace based on the United Nations Charter. Therefore, we must all use our influence to further the cause of peace, but it must be a peace that does not reward the aggressor for its brute use of force. Otherwise, we shall set a very bad precedent; otherwise, we shall undermine the very principles on which the United Nations was founded.

Almost a year has passed since Hamas' horrendous attack on Israel on 7 October 2023. The cruelty and the barbarity we witnessed that day were shocking. I think that none of us is able to really comprehend the shock and trauma that day has caused to Israel and that will forever symbolize the darkest chapter of the country's history. The terrorism of Hamas sparked a downward spiral of human suffering and regional instability. The humanitarian situation in Gaza is catastrophic and the human suffering unbearable. Hundreds of thousands of people have been displaced all over the region. There is a very real risk of an all-out regional war, which would affect not only the people of the region but all of us.

That must end, and it must end now. A ceasefire is urgently needed. All parties should exercise restraint and contribute to de-escalation, and then we should start thinking about the future — not tomorrow or next week but right now. The current horrible situation may also contain the seeds of a new beginning — a new beginning leading to a just and lasting peace for all, unleashing the potentials of the whole region, allowing everybody to see a future for themselves and their children, and breaking the vicious circle of violence that has lasted much too long.

Such a more promising future can be based only on the two-State solution. We all need to work together to create the conditions for that two-State solution to materialize by building the capacity of the Palestinian Authority to take on the role of a legitimate and effective Government in the future Palestinian State, by stabilizing the West Bank and by starting to prepare right now for the early recovery and reconstruction of Gaza. I call on all parties to make such a development possible, to the benefit of the people of Israel, to the benefit of the people of Palestine and thereby to the benefit of the whole region and the world at large.

We often talk about Ukraine and Gaza in these halls but, sadly, people are dying and suffering in conflicts in many other countries. I am deeply concerned about the continued fighting in the Sudan and the humanitarian consequences for the civilian population. More than 10 million people have been displaced. In the Sudan, there is an urgent need for political dialogue and for putting a halt to the conflict, as there is in Yemen, Haiti, Syria, Afghanistan, Myanmar and the Democratic Republic of the Congo. The list tragically goes on and, in the wake of our collective inability to stop the wars, respect for international law is slowly being undermined.

As a small country, Denmark is conscious that our safety and security depend on the international rule of law. Respect for basic United Nations principles — the sovereign equality, territorial integrity and political independence of all States — is fundamental to international peace and security. As we uphold those principles, respect for human rights and international humanitarian law must be at the core.

Denmark is a strong supporter of the international justice system and of the work and independence of the International Criminal Court (ICC) and the International Court of Justice. The International Court of Justice has an important role in the peaceful settlement of disputes, and the ICC is crucial for the global fight against impunity. Without respect for international law, we are looking at a world where might makes right and brute force rules. That is very dangerous.

I began by stating that the vast majority of nations — luckily — seek unity and international cooperation. Earlier this week, we all reaffirmed in the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1) our commitment to the United Nations Charter and outlined a clear direction towards a transformed system of global governance. The existing system has enabled nations to lift millions of people out of poverty, to eradicate diseases and to advance better education for children around the globe. Those are indeed big achievements, but after almost 80 years of service, that system is in need of a serious update.

It is urgent to reform the international financial architecture. It needs to be more representative and more effective. Denmark supports a stronger representation of African countries in the Bretton Woods institutions. We agree that global financial safety nets must support all countries, including the poorest, when a major crisis hits. That should not be dependent on voluntary donor contributions.

We agree that all countries must be subject on an equal basis to independent, transparent and accurate credit ratings. We agree that we need to find sustainable solutions to the high levels of debt faced by many countries. Debt treatment through the Common Framework needs to be accelerated. All creditors and lenders should act transparently, and concessional financing should be made available. The multilateral development banks have mobilized billions already through reforms, but reforms need to deepen to move from billions to trillions.

Looking forward towards the fourth International Conference on Financing for Development, to be held in Spain next year, the twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change and beyond, reform tracks must be made tangible. Solutions should be developed not just for the future but also for the present. I therefore wish to take this opportunity to praise Barbados for suggesting concrete actions to help fix some of the more systemic errors of the international financial architecture. We are happy to support the Bridgetown Initiative for the Reform of the Global Financial Architecture, and we are proud to work alongside Barbados on greening international financing. We encourage others, including the United Nations and the international financial institutions, to work together, to be bold and to achieve the necessary progress on reform of the international financial architecture.

While we reform for a more just financial architecture, we need to sustain levels of development assistance to the poorest countries. Commitments made should therefore be honoured. Denmark remains a member of a club that is absolutely far too exclusive — the club of countries that meet the United Nations target of providing 0.7 per cent of our gross national income for official development assistance. It is a good club, but we have too few members, so we invite others to join.

In April, African Heads of State met in Nairobi to call for an ambitious replenishment of the World Bank's International Development Association (IDA). We

have decided to respond to that call. Denmark intends to increase our contribution to IDA by 40 per cent. For the IDA21 replenishment, we will contribute with \$479 million. We encourage all — be they current or new donors, whether they are big or small — to help us reach an ambitious replenishment.

In June, Denmark was proudly elected to the Security Council for the term 2025–2026. I was present and voting here in the Hall that day (see A/78/PV.86). I wish to thank Member States for their strong show of confidence and support. It will be an honour to serve on the Council. As we look forward to our membership, I cannot help but wish that the Council were in better shape — more accountable, more effective, more transparent and, above all, more inclusive and representative. The world needs a Security Council that reflects the world of today and is able to respond to the security concerns of people all around the globe. To Denmark, it is evident that this calls for an expansion of the Council. We wish to see both more permanent and more elected members, and we wish to limit the use of the veto. Both aspects are long overdue.

Time is of the essence. The year 2030, which once seemed like a distant dot on the horizon, is now only six years away. Yet, only 17 per cent of the Sustainable Development Goals are on track to be realized and we are far from on track to fulfil our climate targets. The accelerating climate crisis must be met with accelerating climate action. We need more ambitious reductions, we need more support for climate change adaptation and we need to speed up and scale up climate financing. No country can solve those global challenges alone, but no country is too small or too big to contribute. Everyone is needed. As a long-standing and dedicated supporter of global cooperation, I can assure Members that Denmark will continue to do our part. We will deliver on promises made and we will push for more ambitious targets and for concrete actions, and we will do so for the present and for the future.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to His Excellency Mr. Maris Sangiampongsa, Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Kingdom of Thailand.

Mr. Sangiampongsa (Thailand): Allow me to begin by congratulating Mr. Philemon Yang on his election to preside over the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session.

I am here today representing Thailand's new Government, led by Prime Minister Paetongtarn Shinawatra, to reiterate Thailand's determination to continue our people-centred, economic-oriented policies to achieve stability and sustainable development for our people.

In an increasingly fragmented and complex world, Thailand reaffirms our support for a rules-based multilateral system, with the United Nations at its core. When the United Nations was founded seven decades ago, we did not envision challenges from technological disruptions, pandemics and climate crisis. In view of the present realities, the United Nations must step up and respond to the evolving challenges of our times if it so to remain relevant. It must be agile and adaptable to new and emerging threats and to ensure that the multilateral system is fit for purpose. Global governance and the United Nations must undertake comprehensive reforms, including that of the Security Council.

With this year's Summit of the Future and general debate, Thailand looks to the United Nations we all need — a United Nations with increased convening power to sustain and strengthen international peace and security; a United Nations that effectively addresses global challenges; a United Nations that improves the lives, equality and dignity of people around the world; and a United Nations that speaks for the aspirations and interests of all nations, not just the most powerful.

Thailand believes that in order for the United Nations to truly sustain and strengthen international peace and security, Member States must uphold their disarmament and non-proliferation obligations to rebuild trust and ensure a safe and secure world. Moreover, various flashpoints around the globe continue to challenge the credibility of the United Nations in resolving conflicts. We are deeply concerned about increasing armed conflicts in Ukraine and different parts of the world, as well as the escalating violence and worsening humanitarian situation in Gaza. Those situations have far-reaching implications for any smaller nation. Therefore, it is incumbent upon us to find peaceful solutions that respect the Charter of the United Nations and human rights.

In our own neighbourhood, Thailand faces challenges from the situation in Myanmar. As Thailand shares the longest land border with Myanmar, we are directly affected by the spillover effect of the situation in that country. We wish to see a peaceful and prosperous Myanmar, which would also bode well for peace and prosperity in the region at large. We believe that a peaceful political solution in Myanmar must be Myanmar-led and Myanmar-owned. That is why we are engaging with all sides, and we will continue to work closely with the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) and the international community to facilitate dialogue among the parties to drive forward the five-point consensus.

As part of that effort, we are stepping up humanitarian assistance to the people of Myanmar through various channels, including the ASEAN Coordinating Centre for Humanitarian Assistance on Disaster Management and relevant United Nations organizations. Thailand will continue to support a peaceful and prosperous Myanmar, not just because it is a pragmatic approach but because it is the right way forward.

Sustainable peace, security and development are closely linked and, to secure a sustainable future, we must accelerate the attainment of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). On Thailand's part, we have been sharing our locally driven, people-centred development approach known as the Sufficiency Economy Philosophy (SEP), to advance the implementation of the SDGs. The SEP for SDGs Partnership is known widely as a best practice on SDG localization.

We are concerned with the slow pace of the implementation of the SDGs at the global level, which is only 17 per cent on track. We must ensure that countries have adequate means and resources to achieve the SDGs, especially through financing for development. The fourth International Conference on Financing for Development next year will provide a key opportunity to address the large and growing SDG financing gap. In that regard, Thailand reiterates the call for reform of the international financial architecture.

In addition to ensuring a just and inclusive financing system, we must also strengthen trade, investment and development cooperation, especially through South-South and triangular cooperation. Thailand is committed to forging stronger partnerships, particularly with least developed countries, landlocked developing countries and small island developing States. Moreover, Thailand's aspiration to become a member of the Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa group and the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development is driven by our desire to build bridges in promoting North-South development cooperation, which is also critical to addressing urgent challenges, such as climate change.

Indeed, Thailand is among the top 10 countries most affected by climate change. Earlier this month, Thailand and many countries in South-East Asia were faced with destructive floods caused by Typhoon Yagi. We therefore advocate a balanced and equal emphasis on both mitigation and adaptation for climate action. To achieve concrete results, we must scale up climate finance. Thailand looks forward to the

twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change, to be held in Baku this November, at which Member States will commit to a new collective quantified goal, grounded in the principle of common but differentiated responsibilities. At the same time, we hope to see the full operationalization of the Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage soon. Climate disasters have taught us that failure to address this matter will delay the achievement of the SDGs and have a widespread impact on human rights and human security. For that reason, the implementation of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction is crucial.

The adoption of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights was an achievement that met the highest aspirations of the people. Today, amid rising inequalities and vulnerabilities, Thailand believes that the United Nations must remain the bedrock of fundamental truths enshrined in the Declaration — protecting the lives and ensuring the equality and dignity of all. For Thailand, protecting and promoting human rights for all not only means guaranteeing basic human dignity, but is also aimed at providing opportunities to advance social justice and equality. With our long-standing policy to protect all persons and groups, especially the most vulnerable, we have made concrete progress in ensuring equal rights for all those living in Thailand, regardless of their origin, belief, sex or gender.

Based on that commitment, Thailand is presenting our candidature to the Human Rights Council for the term 2025-2027. At the Council, we will serve as a bridge-builder to connect different perspectives and work with all stakeholders. We will ensure that all countries are equipped and supported in their human rights actions through experience-sharing and technical cooperation. Moreover, we will also continue to push for the creation of a safe and secure society for all. Recently, we adopted the Marriage Equality Act. On health care, we will continue to advance the right to health by advocating for universal health coverage and the conclusion of a pandemic treaty, as well as advancing the agenda of the Foreign Ministerial Meeting of the Foreign Policy and Global Health Initiative, for which Thailand serves as Chair this year. On crime prevention, we will work closely with all partners to combat increasing drug trafficking and transnational crime in the region and beyond, especially those enabled by digital technology and underground economies.

Thailand welcomes the successful conclusion of the Summit of the Future. In the next step, we have to work together to make the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1) high on impact and high on action by translating it into tangible outcomes. To that end, I have outlined Thailand's vision to achieve the future through what I call the Four Ps. Whether it be building a future where all are protected, where all can prosper, and which is promising for all, it is essential that we commit our collective political will. That means harnessing our political will to promote the power of technologies to help accelerate the SDGs and taking steps to close the digital divide among countries through the Global Digital Compact (resolution 79/1, annex I). We support technology cross-flows and transfers, capacity-building and digital literacy development to enhance the ability of countries to promote people-centred and planet-centric development. It also means giving importance to the Declaration on Future Generations (resolution 79/1, annex II), for our action or inaction today will determine the future. Everywhere, young people and future generations deserve to have big dreams and even bigger doors of opportunities.

Seventy-eight years ago, Thailand looked to the United Nations as a guarantor of a more peaceful and prosperous future. At present, Thailand carries onwards the same belief in a United Nations that is a pioneer of the prevailing peace and drives our peacekeepers and aid workers to serve in remote regions of the globe. In that very same spirit, Thailand pledges to continue to serve as a bridge-builder, fostering

dialogue and trust among nations. We may be nations with different and diverse cultures and traditions, but we are united by our common humanity and aspiration for the future we want. To that end, we must together build the United Nations we need.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to His Excellency Mr. Jeyhun Aziz oglu Bayramov, Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Azerbaijan.

Mr. Bayramov (Azerbaijan): I congratulate Mr. Philemon Yang on assuming the presidency of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session and thank the outgoing President, Mr. Dennis Francis, for his outstanding efforts in leading the previous session.

I also thank Secretary-General António Guterres for his continuous efforts to achieve the noble objectives of the United Nations.

The world continues to grapple with a wide range of challenges that no single country can overcome alone. The worsening global climate crisis, rising inequalities, emerging divides and heightened tensions affect us all, irrespective of our background or location. It is high time to demonstrate that multilateralism works and can deliver with a unified voice, leaving no one behind. The current state of international politics is divisive, with universally accepted fundamental norms and principles of international law being disregarded and misinterpreted.

In the face of the continued erosion of multilateralism, it is paramount that the United Nations continue to foster international solidarity and cooperation. The principles and purposes of the Charter of the United Nations constitute the foundational normative framework of international relations and must be applied consistently, not selectively. The United Nations is mandated to ensure that every nation has an equal voice and is treated on the same footing. In that regard, Azerbaijan advocates for a reinvigorated and reformed multilateral system, with the United Nations at its core, underpinned by strict adherence to and the non-selective application of the universally accepted norms and principles of international law.

Urgent progress is needed on Security Council reform, based on the work done and the gains achieved in good faith and a spirit of flexibility, constructiveness and cooperation.

We view the pivotal Summit of the Future, held a week ago, as a renewal of our common commitment to international law, the United Nations Charter, multilateralism and international cooperation. The Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1), its negotiated outcome, is a blueprint for building a better, more sustainable and prosperous world for everyone. It is time for our collective commitments to turn into real and decisive action.

The global climate crisis threatens decades of progress, imperils humankind's future and disproportionately affects vulnerable countries. The growing divisions in international relations should not distract us from the imperative to address climate change, the greatest transnational challenge of the century. What has been done so far remains insufficient to limit global temperature rise to 1.5°C. For the sake of the future, the time has come for urgent, concerted and sustained efforts to give effect to our commitments to a global vision for sustainable development.

In November, Azerbaijan will host the twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (COP29). Guided by the call "In solidarity for a green world", Azerbaijan will spare no effort to bring developed and developing countries together and foster a collaborative spirit to tackle climate challenges as a common commitment and moral duty. The confidence placed in us by the international community to host and preside over COP29 this year is a

testament and recognition to Azerbaijan's readiness to lead the climate agenda and contribute to global climate action.

As the incoming presidency, Azerbaijan reaffirms its commitment to delivering COP29 in a transparent, impartial, inclusive and party-driven manner. We have presented our vision based on two parallel pillars to enhance ambition and enable action, with climate finance as our top priority this year. Those pillars are mutually reinforcing; progress on each sends a strong signal supporting the other. The primary expectation for the COP29 presidency is an agreement on a fair and ambitious new collective quantified goal (NCQG) on climate finance. That will be the first major climate finance goal after adopting the Paris Agreement on Climate Change and we have been working tirelessly to support the parties in landing a deal. The COP29 presidency has made it clear that agreeing on a fair and ambitious NCQG that is adequate to the urgency and scale of the problem and takes into account the needs and priorities of developing countries is the ultimate test of the parties' commitment to the Paris Agreement and climate action in the years ahead. We need to continue to work constructively on the NCQG and steer the process to a successful outcome at the COP29.

The COP 29 presidency is also working with the parties to deliver an outcome on carbon markets this year. Fully functioning carbon markets will be a significant step in implementing nationally determined contributions (NDCs) cost-effectively and in bolstering ambition for mitigation. Moreover, we have put forward 14 initiatives covering topics such as the link between climate action and the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), green energy zones and corridors, energy storage, harmony for climate resilience, agriculture, clean hydrogen, methane reduction from organic waste, green digital action and more. One of the initiatives under the COP29 Action Agenda includes the establishment of the Climate Finance Action Fund, an innovative source for climate finance to be voluntarily supported by fossil fuel-producing countries and companies.

COP29 will also be an opportunity to set differences aside and contribute to global peace and the climate agenda. Given the intersection of conflicts and the increasingly challenging climate crisis, Azerbaijan has introduced a flagship COP29 truce initiative, embedded in the Joint Solemn Appeal announced a few days ago. More than 1,000 non-governmental organizations, faith leaders and prominent personalities, as well as many parties, have already joined the Appeal. We call on everyone to transcend political divergences, stand in unity and respect the truce during the month of COP29.

Azerbaijan has always been at the forefront of promoting international peace and security, interreligious and intercultural dialogue, contributing to the 2030 Sustainable Development Agenda and fostering global solidarity and multilateralism. The Azerbaijani chairmanship of the Movement of Non-Aligned Countries from 2019 to 2023 was marked by the Movement's enhanced role and increased contributions to a collaborative spirit in international relations. Under the visionary leadership of the President of the Republic of Azerbaijan, Mr. Ilham Aliyev, decisive steps were taken to enhance international solidarity and galvanize the collective response to global challenges at a time of erosion of multilateralism. Guided by the noble call to leave no one behind, Azerbaijan continues to lend its support to developing countries in need. Since 2020, we have provided humanitarian, economic and technical assistance worth \$330 million to over 140 nations.

As we pass the halfway mark of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, we observe stagnation in its implementation. With only 17 per cent of SDG targets on track, we need urgent and accelerated progress. At the national level, we are taking necessary measures to implement the SDGs and setting an example for others to

follow. We have fully embraced the SDGs nationally, prioritizing 17 goals, 88 targets and 119 indicators. That has been achieved through collaborative and inclusive process involving civil society, the business community, youth and other key stakeholders. Azerbaijan's gross domestic product (GDP) has risen fourfold in less than two decades. Poverty has gone down from 49 per cent to 5 per cent. The external public debt is expected to be some 7 per cent of the GDP for 2024, one of the lowest globally.

Clean environment and green growth are among the five priority areas of our new national development strategy. In line with that, Azerbaijan is looking into ways of achieving further greenhouse gas emission reductions and working on its 1.5°C aligned NDC. A few months ago, we joined the 2030 Global Methane Pledge. We will also establish green energy zones and achieve carbon neutrality by 2050 in the Garabagh and Eastern Zangazur regions.

Azerbaijan will continue to play an essential role in global energy security, contributing to sustainable development and the eradication of poverty and helping millions to transition to clean energy in the region and beyond. The share of renewables in the total installed electrical capacity in Azerbaijan will reach 30 per cent by 2030. That high target has been established primarily to improve energy efficiency and introduce innovative solutions in the urban environment, transport systems and industry. The projected increase in renewable electricity production in the coming years will allow Azerbaijan to become an exporter of green electricity to European countries through the landmark transregional Black Sea Submarine Cable project.

In the face of increasing challenges, coming together in unity and solidarity and fostering dialogue and mutual understanding is an absolute necessity. With a centuries-long tradition of diversity and multiculturalism, Azerbaijan firmly believes in dialogue and the collaborative spirit, mutual understanding and respect among different cultures and religions. Azerbaijan has placed particular focus on the promotion of a culture of peace and encouraging intercultural and interreligious dialogue worldwide, including through the Baku Process and Peace4Culture initiatives.

Mr. Marschik (Austria), Vice-President, took the Chair.

The end of armed conflict with Armenia and the restoration of Azerbaijan's sovereignty and territorial integrity have created a substantially new environment in the South Caucasus. For the first time in decades, stability has been achieved on the ground and de facto peace established. By putting an end to military occupation, it is Azerbaijan that created the conditions for both parties to eventually turn the page of enmity and embark on good-neighbourly relations.

That process was launched by Azerbaijan in the immediate aftermath of its victory in the 44-day Patriotic War. The offer was made despite the fact that unhealed wounds from the conflict still persist to date in the form of the dozens of cities and hundreds of towns and villages that have been razed to the ground, the destruction and desecration of each and every piece of historical and cultural heritage and the barbaric pillage of natural resources. Azerbaijan has demonstrated political wisdom and goodwill by offering Armenia peace on equal terms, fully in line with the norms and principles of international law, on the basis of mutual recognition of and respect for each other's sovereignty and territorial integrity.

Over the past year, Azerbaijan and Armenia have registered significant progress in the normalization process through direct bilateral negotiations, in particular with respect to drafting a bilateral agreement, the delimitation and demarcation of the State border and the elaboration of a set of confidence-building measures. Azerbaijan will

continue to take that process forward acting with a strong sense of responsibility for not only its national security and well-being, but also for ensuring a better future for the entire region. Our commitment and determination remain intact to bring the process to its logical conclusion.

For the finalization of the normalization process, Armenia has yet to legally abandon its territorial claims against Azerbaijan once and for all by implementing constitutional amendments. Armenia's negligence with respect to the implementation of constitutional amendments, combined with a dramatic increase in its military budget, its acquisition of a large amount of offensive weaponry from both traditional and new suppliers, and its attempts to maintain obsolete conflict-driven narratives and structures, is derailing the normalization process. The establishment of peace and good-neighbourly relations cannot be sustainable and irreversible if recognition of the sovereignty and territorial integrity of Azerbaijan remains in legal limbo or is contingent on domestic legal or political scenarios. Partial peace is not an option after so much pain and suffering inflicted by irredentism and territorial claims against neighbours. At this critical moment, Azerbaijan calls for expeditious steps to address the remaining impediments to the finalization of the normalization process with a full sense of responsibility.

Along with Armenia's responsibility to honour its international obligations and previously undertaken commitments, it is also incumbent on the entire international community to encourage the sides to establish genuine, sustainable and irreversible peace. Such a peace should outweigh any dividend that might be expected by manipulating one side against the other or building dividing lines between them. Practices that brought devastation to other parts of the globe must cease to be projected to the South Caucasus by feeding revanchism.

Ensuring justice with respect to serious war crimes and crimes against humanity is of vital importance in terms of healing the wounds of the past conflict. While accountability and redress serve to ensure the rights and interests of the victims, they are also key prerequisites on the path to genuine post-conflict normalization and reconciliation. In that regard, it is of paramount importance to shed light on the fate of about 4,000 Azerbaijanis who have gone missing due to the conflict. Resolving that issue is essential not only in terms of accountability and the rights of the victims and their families, but also for post-conflict reconciliation and normalization.

Around 300,000 Azerbaijanis expelled from Armenia continue to be deprived of their ancestral homeland, in blatant violation of international law. Despite repeated calls by the western Azerbaijan community to launch a dialogue and ensure a safe and dignified return to the homeland, the Government of Armenia is preventing them from exercising their fundamental right of return enshrined in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights, the Convention Relating to the Status of Refugees and other important international acts.

Along with the inter-State process of normalization, Azerbaijan has internally embarked on large-scale post-conflict rehabilitation and reconstruction efforts aimed at ensuring the right of hundreds of thousands of Azerbaijanis to eventually exercise their violated right to a safe and dignified return to their homes. Thanks to the tireless efforts made by the Government, life is now returning to territories that witnessed unprecedented destruction during the military occupation.

Regrettably, the massive contamination of territories of Azerbaijan by landmines and other explosive devices remains a significant obstacle to the smooth progress of rehabilitation and reconstruction efforts. Since the end of the conflict in 2020, 377 individuals, including civilians, have fallen victim to landmines. With that in mind, Azerbaijan has introduced a national goal, SDG18, focusing on mine action.

Given the scale of the problem, there is an urgent need for increased international support to strengthen Azerbaijan's humanitarian mine-action capacity. I take this opportunity to thank all countries and other stakeholders that have generously contributed to humanitarian demining in Azerbaijan and reiterate our call for increased international support and solidarity.

In conclusion, I wish to reaffirm Azerbaijan's commitment to further contributing to international peace and security by promoting respect for international law and investing in international solidarity and cooperation. We remain a strong proponent of combined efforts to overcome challenges and pave the way for a brighter future for ourselves and the generations to come.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to His Excellency Mr. Amery Browne, Minister for Foreign and CARICOM Affairs of the Republic of Trinidad and Tobago.

Mr. Browne (Trinidad and Tobago): Permit me to first extend congratulations, on behalf of the Government and the people of the Republic of Trinidad and Tobago, to Mr. Philemon Yang on his election as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. We are confident that he will be equal to the task, and I assure him of Trinidad and Tobago's full support and cooperation.

Allow me to also extend, on behalf of the proud people and Government of Trinidad and Tobago, our sincerest appreciation to his predecessor and our fellow countryman, Mr. Dennis Francis, for his astute and exemplary leadership as President of the Assembly at its seventy-eighth session, which was underpinned by the principles of peace, prosperity, progress and sustainability.

I applaud President Yang on his chosen theme for the seventy-ninth session as our global community finds itself at an inflection point that will determine the fate of future generations. Our planet really should have been in better shape in the year 2024, but instead we are deeply disturbed and dismayed by fresh divisions, the flouting of international law, gross violations of human rights and the flourishing of illegal settlements and oppression, which threaten peace and security around the world. Further, the alarm bells on the climate crisis have long been sounded, and yet we race towards a point of no return. The dream of ending persistent inequality remains a challenge to the global community and hard-earned progress on gender equality appears to have stagnated in some parts of the world.

It is for those reasons that Trinidad and Tobago welcomed the convening of the Summit of the Future and joined with the international community in the adoption of the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1). The adoption of the Pact represents a renewal of our commitment as Member States to multilateralism as the best way forward.

Since the dawn of civilization, humankind has endeavoured to become an improved version of itself in the pursuit of a better quality of life, human rights, equality, dignity and prosperity. Our ingenuity as human beings has paved the way for some of the world's greatest inventions and advancements. Regrettably, in our quest to find the best version of ourselves, we have discovered some of the worst aspects of humankind. Our planet and its people have been subjected to misuse and abuse, the effects of which have left the majority of the global population facing some version of a doomsday scenario. Now more than ever, we must summon a spirit of cooperation and collectively put our shoulders to the wheel for the benefit of all humankind. We used to say that our future depends on it, but now we have to say that our existence depends on it.

It is very well established and accepted that there can be no sustainable development without peace. If we fail to find credible solutions to the global

challenges, humanitarian crises and conflicts around the world, the international community will have squandered its responsibility and perpetuated a vicious downward cycle of regression. One example is the Russia-Ukraine war, which is still ongoing almost three years after Russia's initial invasion — which we have condemned — with profound implications for the world order.

Trinidad and Tobago is deeply troubled by the escalation of conflict and tensions in the Middle East. We remain distressed by the ongoing war on Gaza and by the chilling flashpoints of expansion that are being deployed. Only someone absolutely bereft of humanity would think that it is lawful and just, or even godly, to respond to atrocities committed on one awful day of terror by in turn committing atrocity after atrocity. How else are we to describe the killing of over 200 United Nations staff members — the highest death toll in United Nations history — and the deaths of tens of thousands of civilians, including women and children? And that is not being done in secret; the entire world is watching, and the global South in particular is appalled.

The question remains: If innocent civilians including women, children and United Nations staff were being killed at that record rate in the developed world, how would the world's big Powers have reacted? Not likely with euphemisms and platitudes. The double standards and continued resourcing of those ongoing violations of international law send a chilling message to the global South, and that message is this: There are some powerful people in this world who are of the view that a Palestinian child is less worthy of defence, protection, food, water and life than another child. I am not of that view. The people of my country are not of that view. The Caribbean Community (CARICOM) is not of that view. And decent people all over the world, including in Israel, are not of that view.

International law is not a tool of mere convenience to be muted for our friends and trumpeted against our enemies. In that regard, Trinidad and Tobago has joined in the call for an immediate, full and complete ceasefire and for the unconditional release of every single hostage. The truth is, there is no military solution to the conflict, as peace will be achieved only through negotiations in good faith and constructive dialogue among all concerned parties. Trinidad and Tobago has consistently expressed our support for a two-State solution whereby Israelis can live without the daily threat of terror and Palestinians can live without the daily weight of occupation, coexisting side-by-side as responsible members of the international community. We firmly believe that this is the only credible pathway to end the cycle of violence, culminating in the establishment of a sovereign and peaceful State of Palestine alongside a sovereign and peaceful State of Israel within secure borders.

Rooted in that belief, Trinidad and Tobago took the decision to recognize the State of Palestine as our contribution to the two-State solution and in support of the legitimate aspirations of the Palestinian People to self-determination. I can report that just six days ago, Trinidad and Tobago and the State of Palestine officially established diplomatic relations. We look forward to the day when the State of Palestine will be welcomed to take its seat in the General Assembly as a full Member of the United Nations.

I now turn to the issue affecting the International Criminal Court (ICC). Despite its detractors, the evidence before us clearly shows the value, effectiveness and necessity of the International Criminal Court. As a country that advocated for the establishment of the ICC, via the tireless work of our former Prime Minister and President A.N.R. Robinson, Trinidad and Tobago remains resolute in our support of the Court's mandate to help put an end to impunity for the perpetrators of the most heinous crimes and to provide a glimmer of hope to all victims of those crimes seeking justice within the jurisdiction of the Court. To that end, we continue to encourage all States that have not yet done so to ratify and fully implement the Rome Statute of the

ICC. It was the late Reverend Martin Luther King Jr, who once said, “It is not possible to be in favour of justice for some people and not be in favour of justice for all people”. For that reason, Trinidad and Tobago condemns, rejects and repudiates any and all attempts to impede, intimidate or improperly influence the Court and its very courageous officials.

We are mindful that the illicit traffic in small arms and light weapons in our own region poses an intolerable threat to national security and the lives of our citizens. The proliferation of illegal arms and ammunition has contributed to unacceptable increases in the levels of gun-related violence and fatalities in our small society and, indeed, across CARICOM. In addition to our own efforts domestically, we continue to work with regional and international partners to free our citizens from the horrific human cost associated with easy access to small arms and light weapons and their vicious use against citizens and families. Following the hosting by Trinidad and Tobago of our first Regional Symposium on Crime and Violence as a Public Health Issue in 2023, CARICOM Heads met in Guyana earlier this year to further elaborate innovative strategies on that matter of grave regional concern. Trinidad and Tobago welcomes the renewed efforts of our partners, including the United States of America in particular, to work with us constructively to help solve that deadly challenge, which respects no borders.

We also remain deeply concerned by the humanitarian and security crisis affecting the nation of Haiti. Earlier this year, from this very rostrum, Sir Hilary Beckles, Chairman of the CARICOM Reparations Commission, stated,

“We are calling for justice for the people of Haiti, who should have been held aloft for being the first nation to end the evil of slavery. They should have been held aloft for being the most noble exemplars of freedom and the celebration of democratic possibilities in Western modernity. Instead, for their audacity of action, they were punished by the Western world and demonized rather than deified.” (*A/78/PV.64, p. 4*)

We acknowledge that the path towards a stable and secure Haiti requires indigenous, Haitian-led and Haitian-owned solutions that are ably supported by the United Nations and the international community. In that regard, we welcome the news of the appointment of an interim Prime Minister and Cabinet. We believe that those are important steps in confronting the political, security and humanitarian challenges in Haiti. I salute the role of CARICOM, its secretariat and Eminent Persons Group in helping the Haitians to achieve some of that progress.

Trinidad and Tobago joins in commending the Kenyan Government for its deployment and leadership of the Multinational Security Support mission, and we extend our appreciation to all States that have contributed to that operation, including Jamaica, the Bahamas and several others in our region. An essential component of the success of the Multinational Security Support mission is funding. In that regard, the Government of the United States of America has led by example and contributed the lion’s share, and Canada has stepped up as well. But some relatively wealthy countries have either contributed dribs and drabs or nothing at all. We appeal to the international community to contribute the necessary funding to support that critically important venture.

Our quest to achieve human dignity within the context of sustainable development cannot be divorced from the legitimate calls for reparatory justice for the history of chattel slavery and native genocide in the Caribbean and elsewhere. The brutality of our colonial experience, the trauma of which still affects us to this day, has contributed significantly to underdevelopment. Our foreparents were rooted out and dehumanized, and their blood and sweat and tears and labour were extracted

to build empires and beautiful castles and bridges and treasures, which some of us pay money today to visit and photograph and admire.

We have been leveraging our collective voice to call for restitution for the historical, evil injustices and crimes against humanity committed against our foreparents — crimes that still affect us today. In reaffirming our commitment to that regional campaign, the Government of Trinidad and Tobago appointed last year a reconstituted National Committee on Reparations to provide additional energy and support to the CARICOM Reparations Commission and its work with the African Union and other like-minded bodies. On a related note, we wish to join with those who are committed to and would welcome the proclamation of a second International Decade for People of African Descent.

It is indeed troubling that as we approach the thirtieth anniversary of the Beijing Platform for Action, women and girls in some parts of the world are still denied basic human rights and freedoms and that in some quarters there have been erosions of gains previously made. Trinidad and Tobago continues to be a strong advocate for the meaningful participation of women and girls in all aspects of society, as we recognize and value their critical role in the promotion and protection of human rights and in the building of peaceful and sustainable societies. That is important to us, and as we have done biennially since the year 2010, Trinidad and Tobago will submit to the First Committee this year our draft resolution on women, disarmament, non-proliferation and arms control, and we encourage Member States to support that forward-looking resolution.

The fourth International Conference on Small Island Developing States was held in Antigua and Barbuda earlier this year and underscored the critical nature of the next decade for small island developing States (SIDS). We are very proud of what our fellow CARICOM member State achieved in successfully hosting that impactful Conference. Trinidad and Tobago anticipates that the robust implementation of the Antigua and Barbuda Agenda for SIDS will bring us closer to sustainable development, with the necessary means of support from the international community.

We all acknowledge the adverse effects of climate change. We anticipate decisive outcomes regarding the new collective quantified goal at the upcoming twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change in Baku, which should catalyse much-needed reform of the international financial architecture. Effective climate finance mechanisms are essential to the provision of accessible, adequate and predictable funding, and that requires the operationalization and capitalization of the Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage. Climate finance goes well beyond project funding; it is an investment in the resilience and sustainability of the most vulnerable nations. The future beckons — a future in which SIDS have the capacity and resources to build infrastructure that can withstand severe climate events. That future would enable a just transition to renewable energy sources and the full protection of our natural ecosystems.

Like many others, Trinidad and Tobago has long called for the application of new multidimensional parameters for decision-making on access to financing. In that regard, we welcome the recent adoption by the General Assembly of resolution 78/322, on the multidimensional vulnerability index (MVI). We encourage the international community and the relevant financial and development institutions to utilize the MVI, as it takes into account the realities that undermine sustainable development.

Trinidad and Tobago stands in full solidarity with the people of Cuba, who have been subjected to an unjust embargo for more than six decades. That embargo severely

undermines Cuba's prospects for attaining economic stability, growth and sustainable development. Whatever the objectives may have been 60 years ago, those measures have clearly achieved no desirable results but only the pain and suffering of ordinary people. The collective punishment of an entire citizenry through unilateral coercive measures is not only unconscionable, but also inconsistent with international law and the Charter of the United Nations. Trinidad and Tobago therefore renews its call for the unconditional lifting of the economic, commercial and financial embargo against Cuba. Additionally, we have seen no justification for the designation of Cuba as a State sponsor of terrorism. We call for the removal of that unjust categorization as well.

I shall conclude as I started. This world — our world — is at a point of inflection. With tension and division rising to a crescendo, small States have to be clear-eyed about their future. Trinidad and Tobago is small, but we are proud of that which makes us special and unique. We may not be a super-Power, but we have superpowers, and those are our creativity and diversity. Our cultural milieu is indescribably vibrant, as our people are drawn from the first peoples of our hemisphere, as well as the best of India, the best of Africa, the best of China and, yes, the best of Europe too.

We are blessed beyond measure. Some of those present today had a taste of it at the reception at which we introduced our President of the last session, and they enjoyed some of our delicacies, including our delicious doubles and bake and shark, and were delighted by performances on our national musical instrument, the steelpan, and by the magical rhythms of our tassa drums. We have proven that we can be great leaders, including leaders of this very Assembly, and we will continue to give more value to this world than we extract from it. We are strong, proud, staunch advocates of the United Nations system and multilateralism. In the end, unity and togetherness are the key for these United Nations, as well as for my own society.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to His Excellency Mr. Francis Fonseca, Minister for Foreign Affairs and Foreign Trade of Belize.

Mr. Fonseca (Belize): The self-determination of a people is sacrosanct. It is because of the exercise of that right to self-determination that each nation enjoys the privilege of sitting in the Hall. Our nations exist by the will of our people, by virtue of their right to determine their political status and pursue their economic, cultural and social development. To borrow words from Nelson Mandela, our people are the real makers of history; their participation in every decision about the future is the only guarantee of true democracy and freedom. If we look at the challenges that our people confront today, we must ask whether that sacrosanct principle of self-determination is in fact secure.

Belize is a member of the Alliance of Small Island States (AOSIS), one of 39 countries that have been on the front lines of the climate crisis. The genesis of the crisis lies with the industrialized nations; its perpetuation and acceleration rests with the wider membership of the Group of 20 (G-20). Currently, the G-20 accounts for some 80 per cent of global emissions. AOSIS members contribute less than 1 per cent of global emissions. This is a tale of two worlds, but we only have one planet to share. The extent to which G-20 economies are advancing and contributing to global economic output and world trade is impressive and promising for their people. It is important that their growth be calibrated to a world where small island developing States (SIDS) also have a secure future. That is still possible, but it is urgent.

As SIDS, our people's livelihoods have long depended on traditional sectors such as agriculture, fisheries and tourism, which are climate-sensitive. Opportunities for diversification have been limited by our size, population and location. Climate

change is forcing us to break with tradition and to transition despite the limited options to do so. Each step forward is met with yet another hurdle to overcome and with increasing probability we face the likelihood of setbacks as climate change impacts worsen. The costs are multiplying, fiscal space is shrinking and the opportunities to equitably share in global prosperity are diminishing.

The right of SIDS to define their own future must be protected and secured. The severe impacts of sea level rise have irreversible consequences for SIDS. Our people have gone beyond their duty to protect and preserve our environment, yet some are being forced to relocate from their homelands. To that, we reiterate that no matter the physical changes that climate change may bring to our territory, our sovereignty and our right to self-determination remain intact.

The perpetual suffering of a people can never just be a matter of national concern. The United Nations rose up from the ashes of war to restore,

“faith in fundamental human rights, in the dignity and worth of the human person, in the equal rights of men and women and of nations large and small, and to establish conditions under which justice and respect for the obligations arising from treaties and other sources of international law can be maintained, and to promote social progress and better standards of life in larger freedom”.

All Members of the United Nations have a duty to give effect to those words.

Conflicts should not be allowed to fester. The war in Ukraine has been raging for two years running now and we are concerned that the end is still not near.

Haiti has seized our attention once again. For Belize, the international response must be enduring to ensure long-lasting peace and security of our sister country. We are working through the Caribbean Community to reinforce and strengthen Haiti, and we commend the Haitian people in their resolve to define their own pathway forward. We are pleased to be contributing personnel to the Multinational Security Support (MSS) mission. Belize is extremely worried that, up to now, the international community has not fully delivered on its commitments to the MSS mission or the United Nations Humanitarian Needs and Response Plan for Haiti. That jeopardizes all efforts to establish political stability but, more than that, puts the future of Haiti at substantial risk.

Cuba should no longer be subject to an unjust and illegal economic embargo imposed by the United States. It is imperative that Cuba be removed from the list of state sponsors of terrorism. That arbitrary and unilateral designation has created an unnecessary barrier to global cooperation, constructive engagement and the promotion of peace and stability in our region.

Belize rejects the continued denial of self-determination of the Palestinian people and calls for the eradication of the system of colonial domination and apartheid being imposed upon them. As Belize stated to the International Court of Justice with respect to the recent advisory opinion,

“Israel cannot be permitted to continue flouting one of the most fundamental principles of international law with impunity. Impunity breeds inhumanity.”

Just two weeks ago, the Assembly adopted resolution ES-10/24, proposed by Palestine, affirming the International Court of Justice advisory opinion and called on Members to act to re-enforce the Palestinian people’s right to self-determination. The war, the oppression and the inhumanity must end.

Taiwan is a nation that espouses democracy, development and innovation. The challenges we are tackling as an international community requires Taiwan's full inclusion and participation in the international system. Belize calls for that to be done immediately.

The people of Western Sahara should be granted their long overdue referendum to decide their own future. Belize reiterates its repeated call on the United Nations and the international community to take the necessary steps to allow the Sahrawi people to finally exercise their right to self-determination.

I submit to the Assembly that the foundation of leaving no one behind requires that we actively promote and protect the right to self-determination in its most basic form, in the context of peace and security. Now we must also do so in the context of sustainable development. We have adopted a rescue plan to steer the Sustainable Development Goals back on course. We have the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1). We must use every opportunity to put in place the systems and financing necessary to turbocharge our sustainable development and climate goals. In that effort, we must ensure equal opportunity for all to share in global prosperity. We must raise collective ambition and invest in all our people to empower them to rise.

The Declaration on Sea Level Rise and Statehood, adopted by the leaders of the Alliance of Small Island States (AOSIS) on 23 September, affirms that the sovereignty or statehood of small island developing States cannot be challenged under any circumstances of climate change-related sea level rise. We invite all United Nations Member States to support the implementation of the Declaration and to use it as the basis of international cooperation.

To further guarantee that SIDS will be spared the gravest climate threats, global warming must be limited to well below 1.5°C. Belize urges the G-20 to enhance its emission reduction targets to achieve that temperature limit.

For SIDS, adaptation is imperative, and loss and damage associated with climate change are inevitable. The new climate finance goal to be decided in Baku must contain specific recommendations for minimum allocation to SIDS in relation to grant-based and concessional finance for adaptation and grants for loss and damage. It must also give effect to the provisions of the Paris Agreement on Climate Change, which require enhanced access for SIDS and least developed countries to climate finance. Finally, it must support the urgent capitalization of the Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage.

With the adoption of the Antigua and Barbuda Agenda for SIDS, the United Nations must now ensure its implementation. SIDS must be at the table in global economic and international financial institutions. The multidimensional vulnerability index should be incorporated into existing practices and policies for debt sustainability and development support in order to expand SIDS access to effective development finance.

Belize is moving ahead. We are on a transformative development trajectory. We have dramatically improved our credit profile through the Belize Blue Bonds for Ocean Conservation Project, a debt-for-marine conservation swap. We are reforming and modernizing our legislative and policy frameworks for investments and activating our orange and blue economies, including beyond our national jurisdiction. In partnership with the United States of America, we have signed a five-year \$125 million grant agreement with the Millennium Challenge Corporation, intended to help reduce poverty in Belize by addressing the country's energy and education sectors.

We are making targeted investments to ensure that every child has access to quality education and opportunities. One key example is the Belize Education

Upliftment Project: Together We Rise, which provides half of Belizean secondary school students with the resources they need to succeed, including free tuition, uniforms, school supplies and healthy meals. Belize has extended the compulsory school age to 16 years to improve school retention rates and increase the likelihood of transitioning to higher education. We are working tirelessly to expand vocational training, digital access and life skills development, ensuring that young people are prepared for the evolving job market and capable of driving innovation in sectors such as agriculture, climate change and technology. We are aggressively closing the digital divide, as technology holds the promise of progress, but we depend on multilateral efforts to ensure that all nations, regardless of size or wealth, have the infrastructure and capacity to participate in the digital economy.

Education and capacity-building alone are not enough. Addressing inequalities and fostering inclusion are equally critical to achieving lasting change. The achievement of gender equality and the empowerment of women and girls are central to that effort. Belize has made important progress in that area, marked by the recent launch of its Revised National Gender Policy 2024-2030, which is aimed at ending discrimination and violence against women, while promoting their full participation in all aspects of society — social, economic and political.

Belize continues its work to ensure that every Belizean has access to high quality, affordable and efficient health care services. By January 2025, we will achieve full national health insurance coverage. We are also strengthening our mental health support systems with the goal of improving and expanding access to quality care, addressing the stigma surrounding mental health and enhancing outreach programs, particularly in rural and underserved areas.

Belize is committed to the final settlement of Guatemala's territorial, insular and maritime claim. We welcome Guatemala's stated commitment to respecting and abiding by the ruling of the International Court of Justice. At the political level, we are actively engaged with Guatemala to strengthen our bilateral relationship. A definitive solution will bring greater opportunities for both of our nations in the areas of trade, investment and cooperation.

Belize reaffirms its commitment to the United Nations as the central platform for coordinated global action, but its decision-making processes need to be more inclusive, responsive and representative. Its institutions cannot be held back by the world as it was 80 years ago. Reform is urgent and necessary to reflect the world as it is.

The young people of today have given us a clear, undeniable mandate. They demand action, accountability and a future where they are heard, seen and respected. We ignore them at our own peril. We must not fail them. It is our responsibility to heed their calls for change. We must deliver on our commitments and build a world that present and future generations deserve.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to His Excellency Mr. Olushogun Adjadi Bakari, Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Benin.

Mr. Adjadi Bakari (Benin) (*spoke in French*): It is with a great sense of honour that I stand before the General Assembly today, on this emblematic rostrum of the United Nations, on behalf of President Patrice Talon, President of the Republic of Benin.

Allow me at the outset of my remarks to reaffirm the unwavering commitment of the Beninese people to democracy, political stability and the principle of the peaceful transfer of power. Since the historic Conference of the Active Forces of the Nation in February 1990, Benin has chosen the path of democracy and under the

leadership of successive Presidents, including current President Patrice Talon, we have been able to preserve and strengthen our institutions. Our Defence and Security Forces, with courage and republican commitment, continue to protect our territory and our institutions. Any impulse for destabilization, whether internal or external, will be defeated. Our march towards development is now irreversible.

Today, the world is facing growing tensions and uncertainty is becoming a constant of our time. Every day, we see increasing polarization, with crises everywhere undermining global cohesion and jeopardizing the future of humankind. Be they in the Sahel, the Sudan, Ukraine, the South China Sea or the Middle East, emerging conflicts are undermining global peace and stability. Those tensions bring nothing but suffering and desolation, setting off waves of poverty that affect the most fragile economies and exacerbate the vulnerability of populations.

Although Africa is often far removed from the origin of those crises, it is nonetheless deeply affected. The Sahel region in particular is today the scene of growing tensions, exacerbated by decisions taken without the consent of Africans. That instability seriously compromises our sustainable development. Even more worrisome is the fact that certain external forces are seeking to import their geopolitical rivalries into our region. Benin strongly denounces any attempt to make the Sahel a new epicentre of geopolitical struggles. Such interference fuels the breeding ground for terrorism, an abomination that we condemn without reservation. Be it in Africa or elsewhere, terrorism is unacceptable. No cause can justify the terror or the suffering and destruction that it causes.

Today, we reaffirm our commitment to African unity. More specifically in our West African region, we have the historic responsibility to preserve the age-old brotherhood that unites our peoples. Benin is ready to play its part in that battle against terrorism and for development. Our unity of action is essential regardless of the organizations to which we decide to belong. This is an opportunity for us to reaffirm the commitment to non-violence that led us to condemn the war in Ukraine, the terrorist attacks of 7 October 2023 and the escalating violence it unleashed in the Middle East, as well as all the violence that plunges our brother countries in the Sahel into mourning every day. We call on the international community to step up its efforts to restore stability through dialogue, whether in the Middle East, where the two-State solution remains the only viable path, or in Ukraine, the Great Lakes region, the Sudan, Libya or the sister Republic of Haiti.

Despite those hotbeds of tension, we must never lose sight of another major challenge that threatens the future of our world — poverty in all its forms. With five years to go until the 2030 deadline, it is painfully clear that we will not achieve the Sustainable Development Goals, but we must not give up the fight. The fight against poverty remains one of the greatest challenges of our time. Without that fight, there will be neither true peace nor lasting stability.

Africa is the future of the world. In a few decades, our continent will be home to a quarter of humankind. Our young people, bearers of immense creativity, and our natural resources are an indispensable asset for the future of the planet. If that potential is to become reality, however, we must eradicate poverty on our continent. It is urgent to act because each year of delay compromises that future. In 25 years, when most of our countries will have existed for a century, will we still be debating access to drinking water, electricity, health care and education, or will we have finally crossed the threshold that will allow every African to live in dignity? Those are the essential questions we must answer. The time for action has come.

In 2016, Benin embarked on the path of progress under the leadership of President Patrice Talon. We have taken our destiny in hand and initiated major

reforms in education, healthcare and social infrastructure. Today, we are engaged on a trajectory of transformation and development. It is important that the world recognize the efforts African nations like mine, Benin, that are working for their future and taking charge of their own destiny.

If Africa is to take flight, it must also reconcile with its history and deep identity. Just as it is impossible to understand Europe without considering the influence of the Christian Church or to understand the Middle East without understanding and seeking to understand Islam, it is equally impossible to grasp the essence of Africa without fully embracing its beliefs, traditions and civilization. It is in that spirit that Benin, the motherland of Vodún culture, has taken the initiative to correct negative perceptions about that culture — our culture. We want to reveal to the world the richness of our civilization. In knowing and respecting our history, our beliefs and our culture, the world will be able to understand who we are and why Africa is essential to balance and overall development.

But respect for Africa does not stop at recognizing its past. It also involves a modern, action-oriented Pan-Africanism that is committed to reducing poverty and building a prosperous continent and that strives to replace words with action. That Pan-Africanism must translate into concrete action. How can we advocate African unity when it is easier today for a European to travel to Africa than it is for Africans themselves? Benin took the bold, courageous and Pan-African decision in 2017 to waive visas for all African nationals. That gesture is not merely symbolic; it reflects our commitment to building an Africa where every African can feel at home, everywhere on the continent.

More than ever, respect for Africa also involves recognizing its children scattered throughout the world. Our brothers and sisters in the diaspora, forcibly uprooted during the dark hours of the transatlantic slave trade, must find their place within the African community. It is time to heal those wounds and to reforge that sacred bond with those who, although physically distant, carry Africa in their hearts. Afro-descendants are not simply distant members of our family; they are our children, our brothers and our sisters. They embody an essential part of our collective identity. By recognizing their right to return, we say to them, “You have never ceased to belong to this land. Africa is your home, and we await you with open arms.”

This year marks the end of the first International Decade for People of African Descent. On this occasion, Benin has taken the historic step of unanimously adopting a law in the National Assembly that grants Beninese nationality to all Afro-descendants who want it. That act is much more than a simple symbolic gesture; it is an invitation to a common future and a vibrant call for unity and solidarity. Together, Africans, Afrodescendants of the continent and the diaspora will meet the challenges of tomorrow. Together, we will build a strong, prosperous and respected Africa.

Benin is ready to chart the course towards a united, dynamic and open Africa that takes itself in hand and is committed to fulfilling its future. The century of Africa is within reach. It depends on our ability to seize this opportunity to build an Africa where every citizen, whether born on the continent or part of the diaspora, plays a key role in our common renaissance. We are ready.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to His Excellency Mr. Yamazaki Kazuyuki, Chair of the delegation of Japan.

Mr. Yamazaki (Japan): Allow me to deliver this statement on behalf of the Prime Minister of Japan, Mr. Kishida Fumio.

“The world stands at an historical inflection point. Those extreme shifts in history have become distinctive features of the past three years

and will continue to define the years to come. I have stressed that, at times like these, we must overcome divisions and confrontations and promote international cooperation by going back to the basic foundations. In 2022, I called for defending the principles of the Charter of the United Nations and the rule of law, and in 2023, multilateralism with the United Nations at its core, by shedding light on human dignity.

“Russia’s aggression against Ukraine still rages on and we are witnessing a dire situation in Palestine and Gaza. Unfortunately, divisions and confrontations are deepening. In these difficult times, Japan’s position remains unwavering. We should go back to the basic foundations to unite the international community and deepen solidarity. The rule of law and human dignity remain the key to international cooperation.

“Today, I would like to highlight the importance of strengthening governance at both the national and international levels as another foundation for uniting the international community to strengthen the rule of law and protect human dignity.

“At the Summit of the Future, we made a commitment to taking action for the benefit of present and future generations. Building inclusive societies across the international community, where young people, future generations and women can thrive, and achieving the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), while leaving no one behind, are overarching goals that resonate with us. We believe that the international community would also agree that the role of governance is critical in achieving those goals. Such empathy among us provides a common ground for all members of the international community to share and fulfil their responsibilities. My message for this year can be summarized in a simple phrase: inclusive governance with shared responsibility.

“To address unprecedented crises and challenges and to protect and strengthen the rule of law and human dignity, Japan, as a member of the international community, is determined to play a role for stronger governance. First and foremost, we must strengthen governance to work towards international peace and security, which is the foundation of a prosperous society. Next year marks the eightieth anniversary of the United Nations. It is time to transform the United Nations to address the most pressing challenges in peace and security and meet the needs of a new era.

“Russia’s aggression against Ukraine, which has continued for more than two and a half years, poses a blatant challenge to the international order based on the rule of law and shakes its very foundations. There is a host of issues that need to be addressed, including North Korea’s nuclear and missile development, the situation in Gaza and conflict and terrorism in Africa.

“The international community is in need of a United Nations, in particular a Security Council, that is credible and carries out its responsibility effectively. At the Summit of the Future, world leaders issued a clear and strong message on the urgent need to reform the Security Council. In order to respond in good faith, it is essential to begin the development of a consolidated reform model and text-based negotiations as soon as possible. In that regard, it should be underscored that the majority of Member States, including the Group of African States, are calling for the expansion of both the permanent and the non-permanent

membership of the Council. Japan will work with others to achieve a Security Council that is more representative, with developing countries included and effective, reflecting the realities of the international community. Japan also attaches great importance to the role of the General Assembly in the area of international peace and security.

“For the sake of future generations, it is necessary to maintain and strengthen a free and open international order based on the rule of law and to ensure peace, stability and prosperity in the world. It is in that conviction that I have promoted a Free and Open Indo-Pacific. The vision of a Free and Open Indo-Pacific is in line with the goals of the United Nations. Japan will continue to expand our circle of partners that share this vision, and together we will address various challenges facing the international community in a spirit of co-creation.

“Strengthening domestic governance is also essential for international peace, security and prosperity. Japan has continued to spearhead human-centred international cooperation based on the concept of human security. We need to accelerate the efforts of the international community as a whole towards achieving the SDGs. It is also vital to address the root causes of conflict by interlinking humanitarian, development and peace efforts in order to curb the deterioration of humanitarian situations due to protracted conflicts.

“In March this year, during Japan’s presidency of the Security Council, Japan held an open debate on peacebuilding and conflict prevention (see S/PV.9574). We should strengthen the functions of the Peacebuilding Commission, which has a unique convening power, and increase its cooperation with the Security Council to further promote the humanitarian-development-peace nexus.

“In promoting those initiatives, the perspectives of women, youth and rural areas must be taken into account. The women and peace and security (WPS) agenda seeks to achieve sustainable peace through women’s participation and leadership in peacebuilding and disaster recovery processes. When there is governance that enables women’s active participation, the WPS agenda becomes even more meaningful.

“In order to build that type of inclusive society, it is important to nurture future generations so that they can take the lead in various initiatives. To that end, Japan plans to launch a programme to nurture the next generation of leaders in the field of gender. In order to achieve a flexible and resilient future society that is rich in diversity and able to respond to new challenges, Japan will work on promoting youth, supporting research and building networks for young researchers, and holding a forum for the next generation.

“The rural perspective is also important. Japan is trying to utilize the remarkable technology of companies in rural areas, including active, long-established companies and start-ups, to promote projects that can contribute to solving social issues and create a robust virtuous cycle in the economies of both rural areas and overseas.

“Domestic governance is the bedrock of sustainable development, as it underpins countries’ ability to mobilize private investment and domestic financing. At the same time, each country’s achievement of sustainable growth would amount to the sustainability of the international community

as a whole, a process that would then be supported by international governance. The focus should therefore be on governance at all levels.

“Secondly, we should all share the responsibilities for responding to new challenges facing the international community and work together with a new approach.

“I should like to start by addressing the challenge of nuclear disarmament and non-proliferation, my lifelong work as a politician hailing from Hiroshima. Secretary-General Guterres makes that challenge the very first recommendation in his New Agenda for Peace, launched last year. Despite the extended efforts of the international community, the world is now on the cusp of a reversal in the decreasing trend in the global number of nuclear arsenals. We must face up to the situation that nuclear weapons are once again becoming an apparent global risk due to changing geopolitical circumstances and deepening divisions and confrontations in the international community.

“With those serious concerns in mind, I have been steadily taking nuclear disarmament initiatives under the Hiroshima Action Plan to strengthen realistic and practical efforts to realize a world without nuclear weapons. In March, as the President of the Security Council, Japan chaired the ministerial meeting of the Security Council on nuclear disarmament and non-proliferation (see S/PV.9579). Following that effort, on 23 September I hosted a high-level meeting to launch the Friends of a Fissile Material Cut-Off Treaty here in New York.

“Next year will mark 80 years since the atomic bombings of Hiroshima and Nagasaki. As the only country to have ever suffered atomic bombings during war, Japan will further strengthen efforts to promote accurate understanding of the realities of nuclear weapons use as the starting point for all nuclear disarmament measures. Japan will also act to further advance nuclear disarmament as we head towards the 2026 Review Conference of the Parties to the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons.

“Japan will also work even more closely with the international community towards the denuclearization of North Korea, including the full implementation of relevant Security Council resolutions. Japan will continue to seek to normalize its relationship with North Korea, in accordance with the Japan-Democratic People’s Republic of Korea Pyongyang Declaration, by comprehensively resolving outstanding issues of concern, such as abductions, nuclear and missile issues, and the settlement of the unfortunate past.

“The rapid development of emerging technologies is bringing new challenges to disarmament and non-proliferation efforts. Focusing on the further development of emerging technologies, Japan intends to actively and constructively participate in international rule-making on lethal autonomous weapon systems through balanced discussions, taking into account humanitarian and security perspectives, so that a common understanding can be reached within the international community, including stakeholder States.

“In discussing new challenges, we must also include aspects of digital technologies, especially considering that the Global Digital Compact (resolution 79/1, annex I) was just adopted at the Summit of the Future. Digital technologies have the power to transform the future of the

world, thereby making digital cooperation an essential part of protecting and enhancing human dignity.

“Among such digital technologies, there is an urgent need to establish international governance on artificial intelligence (AI) in order to maximize the opportunities brought by AI while mitigating its risks. Japan has been working through the Hiroshima AI Process to achieve safe, secure and trustworthy AI. We will continue to actively contribute to the discussions on AI at the United Nations.

“In tackling global issues, the evolution of the multilateral development banks has emerged as a new issue. Japan will contribute to further progress in the evolution of those banks in a way that reflects the specificities of each institution and the discussions of their boards. Increasing lending capacity to developing countries by utilizing existing capital and private capital mobilization and addressing the debt restructuring faced by those countries are also pressing issues. Transparent and fair development finance, in line with international rules and standards, is needed now more than ever.

“Climate change is a common challenge to all humankind and a critical issue that the international community collectively needs to address. Japan has identified climate change as the greatest challenge that needs to be overcome by bringing about a new form of capitalism. We are steadily taking action and are on track to achieve net-zero emissions by 2050. It is important that all countries come together to achieve the common goal of net-zero through various pathways that are compatible with economic growth and energy security. As an initiative to embody those ideas, Japan has proposed the concept of an Asian zero emission community. We are working with other Asian countries to simultaneously achieve decarbonization, economic growth and energy security in the region.

“What I would like to highlight this year is the importance of inclusive governance upheld by shared responsibility. That requires solidarity among diverse countries. At last year’s Group of Seven (G-7) Hiroshima Summit, I set the strengthening of engagement with partners beyond the G-7 as one of the pillars of the Summit. Since then, Japan has been supporting stronger domestic governance in developing countries to protect human dignity through the exchange of opinions with the Association of Southeast Asian Nations, India and Pacific countries, as well as with Latin American countries, including Brazil, which holds the Group of 20 presidency this year.

“Africa is a region that is experiencing dynamic growth, supported by a young population and the fruits of its efforts to strengthen inclusive governance. At the same time, Africa continues to face challenges related to human dignity, such as poverty, job creation and fragile economic and social infrastructures, as well as challenges related to peace and stability, such as conflict, terrorism and refugees and displaced persons.

“Strengthening governance is important as a lever for change to achieve peace, stability and sustainable development. Investing in human resources and mobilizing domestic and international resources for that purpose is essential for economic transformation that leads to growth.

“As a long-standing partner of Africa, Japan has been supporting the strengthening of ecosystems and governance conducive to domestic and

international resource mobilization, including through assistance for fiscal management and trade facilitation. Japan has also supported elections to consolidate and strengthen democracy and assisted in the capacity-building of administrative and judicial personnel. Furthermore, we have promoted inter-community dialogue to foster a shared future, encouraged the participation of citizens, including young people and women, in the political and reconstruction process, and supported the strengthening of their livelihoods.

“Next year, we will host the ninth Tokyo International Conference on African Development in Yokohama. Together with our African friends and the United Nations, we will find innovative solutions to Africa’s and global challenges. As a part of those efforts, Japan will consider further preferential measures in light of the World Trade Organization decision so that least developed countries (LDCs) can achieve smooth and sustainable development after their graduation from the LDC category.

“At this year’s session of the General Assembly, let us all look towards the same vision for our future and join forces to strengthen governance across the international community. Let us work together for inclusive societies where the rule of law and human dignity are upheld. The United Nations has an important role to play, and the international community is counting on it to fulfil its mandate. As a State Member of the United Nations, Japan will also contribute to that progress.

The Acting President: The exercise of the right of reply has been requested. I would like to remind members that statements made in the right of reply are limited to 10 minutes for the first intervention and five minutes for the second, and should be made by delegations from their seats.

Mr. De La Gasca (Ecuador) (*spoke in Spanish*): My delegation makes use of the right of reply to the statement made by the Minister for Foreign Affairs of the current Government of Mexico, Mrs. Alicia Bárcena Ibarra, regarding the incident that occurred at the Mexican Embassy in Quito on 5 April (see A/79/PV.15).

Ecuador is a country that respects international law and the principles and values contained in the Charter of the United Nations. Let there be no doubt about that. In her intervention, the Minister for Foreign Affairs of the Government of Mexico failed to mention that the incident in question is the subject of a case before the International Court of Justice, in which the Court, accepting the guarantees offered by Ecuador, has rejected Mexico’s request for provisional measures.

Half-truths have been told. Prior to the incident that occurred on 5 April, light was shed on the exceptional circumstances in which the Ecuadorian authorities were forced to enter said diplomatic mission to arrest a fugitive from justice. It was an isolated event that had the objective of combating impunity. It must be said that the current Mexican Government allowed an Ecuadorian citizen sentenced for two crimes of illicit association and subject to additional criminal proceedings, including one for gender violence, to enter and remain in its embassy in Quito as a guest. Despite Ecuador’s multiple diplomatic efforts, the current Mexican Government did not hand over that citizen, who was a fugitive from justice, to the Ecuadorian authorities, as it was obligated to do, and subsequently illegally granted him political asylum.

By acting in that manner, the current Mexican Government breached its obligations under the International Convention on Political Asylum of 1933 and the Convention on Diplomatic Asylum of 1954, which clearly establish that it is not lawful to grant asylum to persons convicted or prosecuted for common crimes by competent ordinary courts, as was the case. The Mexican Government also violated

the Vienna Convention on Diplomatic Relations, which imposes the obligation to respect the laws and regulations of the receiving State, not to interfere in the internal affairs of the receiving State and not to use the premises of a diplomatic mission in a manner incompatible with its functions. In addition, the Government of Mexico violated the principles of sovereign equality, territorial integrity and non-intervention in the internal affairs of other States enshrined in the Charter of the United Nations, the charter of the Organization of American States and customary international law. The Government also violated its obligation to cooperate in anti-corruption matters, in accordance with the Inter-American Convention against Corruption of 1996 and the United Nations Convention against Corruption of 2003.

Those violations of international law cannot be normalized or forgotten. Therefore, on 29 April, Ecuador filed a suit against Mexico before the International Court of Justice.

Mr. Li Linlin (China) (*spoke in Chinese*): In response to yesterday's statement by the representative of Australia (see A/79/PV.14) and today's statement by the representative of the Philippines (see A/79/PV.15), China wishes to exercise its right of reply. China has always believed that the United Nations is not the appropriate place for discussing the South China Sea issue. However, it is necessary for us to make a solemn response, given that erroneous remarks have been made.

The South China Sea arbitration was unilaterally initiated by the Philippines, in violation of the principle of State consent and in contravention of international law, including the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS). The International Tribunal for the Law of the Sea exceeded its authority and made an unjust ruling, and the award is illegal and invalid. China does not accept or recognize the ruling, nor does it accept any claims or actions based on it. China's territorial sovereignty and maritime rights and interests in the South China Sea are not affected by the ruling under any circumstances. China has indisputable sovereignty over the South China Sea islands and their adjacent waters and sovereign rights and jurisdiction over the relevant waters. China's regular patrols, law enforcement and productive activities in waters under its jurisdiction are compliant with international law, including UNCLOS.

The recent escalation of the South China Sea issue between China and the Philippines is entirely the responsibility of the Philippines. China will continue to resolve the disputes on the South China Sea through negotiations and consultations with parties directly concerned, including the Philippines, on the basis of respect for the historical facts and in accordance with international law. China will also continue to work with the countries of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations to safeguard peace and stability in the South China Sea.

Mr. Faheem (Pakistan): I am taking the floor to respond to the remarks delivered by the Minister for Foreign Affairs of India earlier today (see A/79/PV.15).

It is most ironic that India, which is committing the worst form of State terrorism in occupied Jammu and Kashmir while also actively engaging in sponsoring terrorism abroad, is portraying itself as the victim. It is a familiar ploy of all occupiers and colonizers to paint legitimate struggles for freedom and liberation as terrorism. India is failing to grasp the enormity of the indigenous Kashmiri resistance to its stranglehold and wrongly blaming it on cross-border terrorism. It must introspect, reflect and immediately implement the Security Council resolutions that provide for the Kashmiris to exercise their right to self-determination.

It is India that supports and finances terrorism against Pakistan using its proxies. Pakistan has provided irrefutable evidence to the Security Council of India's involvement in terrorist activities against my country. India's campaign to damage

and destroy Pakistan's economy is no secret, including by impeding the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor through the sponsorship of terrorist groups such as the Balochistan Liberation Army and the Majeed Brigade. India is also supporting terrorism in Balochistan province of Pakistan.

India's assassination campaign against its dissidents residing overseas has been exposed in Canada and the United States, while its leaders publicly boast of murdering their citizens abroad. It is India that seeks to expand its territory through unilateral measures to consolidate its occupation of Jammu and Kashmir, in gross violation of international law, and crass threats to cross the Line of Control to take over the liberated territory of Azad Jammu and Kashmir. India's military build-up in nuclear, conventional, new and destabilizing weapons is mainly deployed against Pakistan. India is pursuing highly dangerous war-fighting doctrines to engage in a conventional military confrontation with Pakistan under the nuclear overhang, despite the humiliation suffered by India during its last ill-advised military adventurism against Pakistan in February 2019, in which two fighter jets were lost and a pilot was captured and later released by Pakistan after Indian pleas.

India's quest for regional hegemony is not limited to posturing against Pakistan only but is also evident in its meddling in the internal affairs of Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Maldives. The hubris and grandiose perception being harboured by India, coupled with its fast-growing aggressive military capabilities, are a clear and present danger to international and regional peace and security. India needs to be reined in before it is too late. India must be held accountable for its violations of international law in occupied Jammu and Kashmir, for its State terrorism in the occupied territory and for sponsoring terrorism against Pakistan.

Mr. Yoseph (Ethiopia): I take the floor in exercise of right of reply to a statement delivered by the representative of Egypt against my country, Ethiopia (see A/79/PV.15).

The extensive statement by Egypt's representative can be summarized in short as a categorical rejection of our efforts to ensure a dignified life for our people. While we share no border, Ethiopia is linked with Egypt through the Nile. We believe that the Nile is a solemn nexus between our countries that ought to create shared peace and prosperity for the people of our sisterly countries. It has never been Ethiopia's intention or conduct to create tension and hostility towards Egypt. The speaker made clear to the Assembly Egypt's position against the universally accepted principle of the permanent sovereignty of States over their natural resources and their right to use them for the benefit of their people.

The people of Ethiopia, using their own finances, built the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam. The dam is built over the River Abay, which, as correctly explained by the representative of Egypt, is a tributary of the River Nile. It is bringing light to millions of Ethiopians previously deprived of that basic necessity. It is bringing integration to our region through energy, trade and connectivity. The River Abay traverses two-thirds of Ethiopia's territory and makes up 70 per cent of Ethiopia's water resources. Even with that resource, the people of Ethiopia continue to live in food and energy insecurity. More than half of our 120 million people need access to clean water and electricity. Ethiopia will not be told to halt its efforts to alleviate that unacceptable circumstance. We will not be told that our people do not deserve a dignified life.

Ethiopia recognizes that the River Nile is a transboundary water resource that must be used by all riparian countries, based on the principle of equitable and reasonable utilization. Transboundary resources are also best managed based on basin-wide arrangements agreed to by the riparian countries. When it comes to those

principles of international law, we see a paradox in the Nile basin. Ethiopia, an upper riparian country that contributes 85 per cent of the flow of the Nile, and the other eight source countries seek cooperation based on international law. Egypt, a lower riparian country that contributes no flow to the resource, relentlessly works against cooperation and undermines international principles. It advocates for monopoly based on colonial-era arrangements and seeks a veto over the water development efforts of the countries that originate the water.

Ethiopia will continue pursuing its development on the river Abay on the basis of the equitable and reasonable utilization of the resource. It is our hope that, through time, Egypt will reorient its colonial-based policy on the Nile and work on integrated development on the basis of equity. The time will also come when Egypt realizes that its best interest is intertwined with and best served by cooperation with the riparian countries of the basin. More importantly, the old playbook that seeks to secure the unfettered flow of the Nile by preoccupying the source countries with conflict and insurgencies will not work. On that basis, Ethiopia calls on Egypt to immediately stop its destabilization efforts in the Horn of Africa.

The time to negotiate and find a win-win solution is now. We urge Egypt to choose the path of negotiation and the path of international law. The Nile Basin Cooperative Framework Agreement (CFA) will enter into force on 13 October. Egypt has the golden opportunity to return to the peaceful conduct of its relations with the Nile River riparian States. Egypt is therefore encouraged to ratify the CFA and to play a constructive role in regional development.

Ms. Melikyan (Armenia): I have requested the floor to exercise the right to reply to the statement delivered by the representative of Azerbaijan.

We regret that, despite the forward-looking call of the Prime Minister of Armenia to normalize relations and despite the recent round of ministerial negotiations that took place just two days ago, Azerbaijan used this body not only to express its reluctance to normalize relations with Armenia, but opted to propagate its usual distortions and allegations. Nevertheless, let me once again reaffirm that Armenia is committed to achieving a just and lasting peace in the region and has engaged in negotiations to normalize relations with Azerbaijan based on international law, including the principles of sovereignty and territorial integrity.

However, we have yet to see the same level of commitment and good faith from the Azerbaijani side. In response to all efforts towards the settlement of the long-standing conflict, Azerbaijan continues to present new, unsubstantiated and illegitimate claims to Armenia. The allegation that the Constitution of Armenia contains territorial claims against Azerbaijan is entirely false and has been refuted on a number of occasions. It is strange to hear allegations of a military build-up from a country that for decades has engaged in the uncontrolled and unabated accumulation of offensive weaponry, in violation of literally all its obligations under regional arms control treaties. The military build-up of Azerbaijan has resulted in acts of aggression, with a heavy toll on the civilian population, atrocity crimes, mass displacement and the destruction of critical civilian infrastructure. Armenia is exercising its sovereign right to strengthen its defence capabilities in line with international law. We have stressed a number of times that we do not have territorial claims against any of our neighbours, and we do not plan any aggressive action against any of them.

We regret that Azerbaijan continues to spread false allegations about mines as sheer distortion and propaganda that have twice been rejected by the International Court of Justice. Azerbaijan has consistently used humanitarian demining activities as a pretext to justify its aggressive actions against Armenia and numerous atrocity crimes. Over the past four years, Armenia has unilaterally provided all available maps

of mined areas in its possession as a humanitarian gesture. The Armenian side has also expressed its readiness to support the decoding of the transport maps, in cooperation with international partners.

By contrast, Azerbaijan continues to violate its obligations under international humanitarian law and the orders of the International Court of Justice. The international community should be cognizant of the fact that the country hosting the twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change has yet to release the Armenian hostages it has held for more than one year in captivity or address the remaining humanitarian issues.

At the same time, the issue of missing persons and enforced disappearances remains high on our agenda as well. More than 1,000 Armenians are missing as a result of the conflict. We believe that the issue of all missing persons should be addressed. The Armenian Government commission on missing persons has on numerous occasions offered to hold meetings to that end, but they have been rejected by the Azerbaijani side. We call on Azerbaijan to abide by its legal obligations under international law and international humanitarian law to release all Armenian hostages held for more than one year in captivity and to create an environment conducive to long-lasting regional peace and cooperation. We call upon the United Nations and its Member States to firmly respond to Azerbaijan's failure to comply with its obligations and ensure that the attempts of that country to whitewash gross violations of human rights and humanitarian law by holding international events will not be tolerated.

The concept of so-called Western Azerbaijan reveals the territorial claims of Azerbaijan towards the sovereign territory of Armenia, including its capital. Through such fake historical contrasts and the weaponization of history, Azerbaijan intends to create a pretext to continue its policy of using force in the region. Through those manipulations, Azerbaijan is attempting to distract the attention of the international community from the ethnic cleansing and forced displacement of 115,000 people, the entire indigenous population of Nagorno-Karabakh, from its ancestral homeland one year ago.

Interestingly, the Azerbaijani Minister failed to mention that the Azerbaijanis who left Armenia during the collapse of the Soviet Union did so voluntarily. Furthermore, they received compensation, in comparison to the 360,000 Armenians who were forced to leave their homes and property as a result of State-orchestrated programmes in Baku, Sumgait, Kirovabad and other cities of Azerbaijan. The baseless claims regarding cultural heritage are an attempt to divert attention from the destruction, desecration and appropriation of millennia-old Armenian cultural heritage and acts of vandalism committed by Azerbaijan in Nagorno-Karabakh and, prior to that, in Nakhchivan.

The delegation of Azerbaijan needs to be reminded that the International Court of Justice, in a legally binding order issued on 7 December 2021, mandated Azerbaijan to,

“take all necessary measures to prevent and punish acts of vandalism and desecration affecting Armenian culture heritage, including ... churches and other places of worship, monuments, landmarks, cemeteries and artefacts”.

Even now, Azerbaijan continues to block the deployment of a UNESCO mission to conduct an inventory of the cultural property in Nagorno-Karabakh in an attempt to hide its State-led campaign of the systemic destruction of the historic Armenian legacy of Nagorno-Karabakh following the ethnic cleansing and forced displacement of its entire indigenous population.

Mr. Novicio (Philippines): I wish to refer to the statement made by one delegation referring to the South China Sea arbitration.

We recall 12 July 2016 as the day that affirmed to the community of nations that the rule of law prevails and that stability, peace and progress can be attained only when founded on a rules-based legal order on the oceans, as it should be everywhere else. The award and the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) are the twin anchors of the Philippines policy and actions on the West Philippine Sea. UNCLOS sets out the legal framework within which all activities in the oceans and seas must be carried out. There is no recourse to general international law on matters comprehensively covered by UNCLOS. Compliance with UNCLOS, which represents a delicate balance of the rights and obligation of all States parties in its entirety, is key to ensuring global and regional peace and the fair and sustainable use of the oceans.

The award and affirmation of the UNCLOS dispute resolution mechanisms not only set reason and right in the South China Sea, but is an inspiration for how matters should be considered through reason and right by States facing similarly challenging circumstances. It authoritatively ruled that the claim of historic rights to resources in the sea areas falling within the nine-dash line had no basis in law and was without legal effect. It upheld the Philippines sovereign rights and jurisdiction in its exclusive economic zone (EEZ). It affirmed that certain actions within the Philippines' EEZ violated the Philippines' sovereign rights and were thus unlawful; that large-scale reclamation and the construction of artificial islands caused severe environmental harm, in violation of international conventions; that the large-scale harvesting of endangered marine species damaged the marine ecosystem and that actions taken since the commencement of the arbitration had aggravated the dispute. Those findings are no longer within the reach of denial or rebuttal and are conclusive and indisputable.

The award is final. We firmly reject attempts to undermine it or even erase it from law, history and our collective memories. At the same time, we welcome the support of countries for the award. The award benefits the world across the board. We do not see it as directed at any other country near or far. We see it as it should be seen — as favouring all those that are similarly situated by clarifying definitively a legal situation beyond the ability of arms to change; it puts that aspect of international law beyond the limit of prescription.

We therefore say once again that the present that we need and the future that we want is a peaceful South China Sea. The Philippines is committed to doing so for as long as it exists.

Mr. Musayev (Azerbaijan): In his speech at this general debate (see A/79/PV.12), the representative of Armenia pointed out that the principle of mutual recognition by his country and Azerbaijan of territorial integrity and the inviolability of borders is a fundamental factor for establishing peace. However, we have heard no apology from Armenia for its persistent denial of that very principle for 30 years, as a result of which tens of thousands of people lost their lives. The genocide in Khojaly and numerous other atrocities were committed against Azerbaijani civilians. More than a million Azerbaijanis were expelled from their homes and deprived of their property, and thousands of cities, towns and villages in my country, not in Armenia, were plundered and raised to the ground.

Indeed, it is ironic to hear accusations from Armenia, which has violated every norm and principle of international law and whose agenda throughout the past conflict was to rid the formerly occupied territories of their Azerbaijani inhabitants by force, to prevent their return and to replace them with ethnic Armenians, thereby seeking to

colonize those territories by changing their demography and character. The international community condemned those actions, qualifying them as amounting to ethnic cleansing and a scorched earth policy.

The counteroffensive operation and the local counterterrorism measures carried out by Azerbaijan in the fall of 2020 and in September last year, respectively, put an end to the unlawful occupation of its territories and ensured the restoration of my country's sovereignty and territorial integrity. Azerbaijan fought not against a fictitious entity or civilian residents, as Armenia falsely claims, but against the regular armed forces of Armenia, as well as terrorists and mercenary groups under its command and control, deployed in the then occupied territories of Azerbaijan. The common element in all actions that Azerbaijan was compelled to take in response to Armenia's repeated unlawful use of force was its compliance with international law, the Charter of the United Nations and the relevant resolutions of the Security Council. As to the residents who decided to migrate to Armenia or other countries, it was their choice, although Azerbaijan encouraged them by all available means to stay. If Armenia is genuinely interested in finding out the reasons for that, it should look for the roots in its notorious doctrine of ethnic incompatibility, which it sought to impose as a model for our peoples to live next to each other but not together.

Against the claims made by the representative of Armenia, the United Nations inter-agency mission that visited the region refuted the allegations that the local residents and their property were targeted during the security measures or thereafter. Another false assertion is that Azerbaijan holds Armenian hostages. There are no Armenian hostages in Azerbaijan, while those held accountable for war crimes, terrorist activity and other serious offences committed during the conflict do not enjoy such status by definition. Those measures are fully consistent with the legislation and international obligations of Azerbaijan.

Armenia's feigned concern for cultural property is easily exposed by the numerous instances of its destruction, desecration and appropriation of Azerbaijani cultural heritage, both in Armenia itself and in the territories of Azerbaijan when they were under occupation. Armenia's allegations about Azerbaijan's territorial claims against Armenia are equally groundless, as they totally ignore the simple fact that, despite the ruinous consequences of the aggression, occupation and mass atrocities endured by the people of my country, it was Azerbaijan that extended the hand of peace and initiated the process of normalizing relations with Armenia, based on mutual recognition and respect for each other's sovereignty and territorial integrity. It is due to Azerbaijan's determined and consistent efforts that significant progress has been made in the bilateral negotiations on the draft peace agreement and the delimitation of the border between the two States over the past four years. The return of Azerbaijanis to their historical homeland in Armenia is a human right, not a territorial claim.

With the end of the conflict, an historic opportunity has indeed emerged for a long-awaited peace in our region. However, challenges remain. During this high-level week, we have once again witnessed Armenia's refusal to take practical steps at the national level to root out territorial claims from a number of its legal and political acts, and especially from its Constitution, that laid the basis for the sustained denial of the principle of the inviolability of borders and ultimately underpinned the aggression against Azerbaijan in the past, and that constitute the main obstacle to the normalization of inter-State relations today. While the delegation of Armenia is of the view that there are no territorial claims against Azerbaijan in its Constitution, the same Constitution, however, proclaims that Armenia's declaration of independence, which is based on the earlier act of annexation of a part of the territory of Azerbaijan, enshrines the fundamental principles of Armenian statehood and nationwide

objectives. If that is not a territorial claim, then what is it? Consequently, what Armenia is required to do as the main prerequisite for signing a viable and sustainable peace agreement is to bring its rhetoric about territorial integrity and inviolability of borders in conformity with general respect for that principle in its policies, practice and laws, including, first and foremost, by prior modification of its Constitution.

The unacceptable comments just made by the representative of Armenia, along with the ongoing anti-Azerbaijan smear campaign, including through some third countries, pseudo-experts, lobbyists, the diaspora and non-governmental organizations aligned with shared xenophobic aspirations, clearly contradict Armenia's statements about its interest in creating an environment conducive to moving the peace process forward. Therefore, Armenia must demonstrate not only in words, but mainly in real deeds, that it is generally committed to international law and the peace agenda. Peace is indeed within reach. However, for that to happen, there is a pressing need to address the remaining issues responsibly and to legally ensure that a return to the past of irredentism and aggression is excluded forever.

Mr. Li Linlin (China) (*spoke in Chinese*): In response to the statement made by the representative of the Philippines, China is compelled to make another statement in right of reply.

China does not accept or recognize the so-called South China Sea arbitration, precisely for the sake of the preservation of the international maritime rule of law. The United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) does not represent the entirety of international maritime law. The arbitration initiated by the Philippines boils down to the issue of territorial claims, which are not subject to regulation by UNCLOS.

The so-called arbitration award contains many great fallacies with regard to issues such as historical rights, the outlying archipelago of continental States and the regime of islands. For example, according to the ruling, the largest of the Nansha islands, Taipingdao, has been characterized as a rock. Such a fallacious ruling seriously undermines the credibility of the dispute resolution mechanism under UNCLOS. If that argument, as contained in the ruling, is accepted, then many countries' islands will become rocks and will therefore not be entitled to full maritime rights.

China's position is based on the maintenance of China's territorial sovereignty and maritime interests and rights. It is also driven by the conviction that it is necessary to maintain the integrity and authority of UNCLOS, prevent the Convention from being abused and prevent the international rule of law from being undermined.

Mr. Novicio (Philippines): With respect to the earlier intervention made, allow me to reaffirm that the 2016 South China Sea arbitration is a testament to the Philippines' unwavering commitment to the rule of law and the peaceful settlement of disputes. Over the years, the Philippines has continued to demonstrate that commitment to peace even in the face of the unlawful actions that have caused serious incidents in the South China Sea, without ever diminishing our resolve to protect and promote our people's interests and the full and responsible enjoyment of our legally settled maritime entitlements and their accompanying rights and jurisdictions. That determination has only been strengthened by the broadening affirmation of the legal value of the award as a positive and legitimate source of international law. We are encouraged by the expressions of support made by other States that confirm the final and binding status of the award, including the Group of Seven's consistent reaffirmation that it is a significant milestone and a useful basis for the peaceful management and resolution of differences at sea.

The meeting rose at 7.35 p.m.